



Independent Project

A Business Plan for a digital first platform called HIS

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Declaration

I, Partha Pratim Maity, Student ID 7751206, declare that my Major Independent Project “Human In Sports” is my work. Apart from explicitly recognised material, everything adapted for use is/was recognised and cited under Leeds Beckett University Harvard conventions of referencing. This business plan has never been submitted either entirely or in part to another assessment or grant at LBU or any other institution.

I ensure that I have requested ethical approval where necessary and have acknowledged any research assistance, editorial work or third-party support. I agree to the electronic submission of this dissertation (business plan) and originality detection software to use by the university.

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Executive Summary

Human In Sports (HIS) was founded with a deeply personal experience and idea. When I started working in the sports industry, I work closely with athletes who showed exceptional talent but received little to no recognition. I came across athletes who participated in the national competition like futsal, handball, athletics and provided example of success despite the inadequate facilities and tracks, absence of regulations, starting from absolute zero and came this far to represent the country and be celebrated. Through world sports that commands enormous audience and revenue like football and cricket, there are always niche sports that are not always included in the popular discourse (Bruce, 2016). The desire of HIS is to fill this gap and create an entirely digital first platform that would glorify and bring the niche athletes into limelight and human stories in the forms of podcast, short form videos and athlete branding.

HIS is a digital first sports media company that aims to change sports media through the identification of niche talents and offer authentic stories through this platform that will enhance inclusivity, diversity and sustainability.

The business plan has been designed in two parts. Section one includes the definition of the organisation, vision, mission and the objectives with the support of analytical frameworks such as PESTLE, Porter Five Forces, Blue Ocean Strategy and the Ansoff Matrix. The next section contains the five-year financial plan, breakeven, balance sheet and cash flow forecast along with the marketing & operational plan. Together, these pieces of knowledge evidence the business potential of the venture in the form of sponsorships and brand collaboration as well as aligns with the UN Sustainable Development Goals (United Nations, 2023).

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Chapter 1: Description of the Business

1.1 Background of the Study

HIS is a digital storytelling platform which is created to highlight the achievements of the raw talents and the niche athletes. The project focused on athletes who often go unnoticed by the traditional sports media, sports like futsal, para-athletics and other niche sports. The platform aims to raise awareness and provide visibility through short-form videos, interviews, YouTube podcasts and social media campaigns to reach out wider audience.

Bruce (2016) stated that less than 5% of the traditional sports media coverage is devoted to women or disabled athletes despite the growing participation level of these groups. Another article by Newman (2020) also notes a rising demand for more authentic and athlete-driven storytelling that reflects diverse sporting journeys. HIS understands this need and responds to this need by providing authentic storytelling and interviews by the athletes through this digital first model.

1.2 Reasons behind the Business Concept

The idea of Human is Sports struck from this experience working with niche athletes whose commitment often went unnoticed due to limited opportunities and media visibility. In today's date there is a growing demand for authentic and raw value-led content, especially between Gen Z and the millennials who prioritise inclusion and representation (Statista, 2024). Also, at the same the rise in the economy of the creators and accessible media tools has created new space for alternative narratives to reach a wider audience (Influencer Marketing Hub, 2023). HIS tackles and responds to this by offering a platform that highlights the journey and struggle of the athletes and not just celebrate their fame.

The vision and mission statements serve the as a strategic anchor (Kaplan and Norton, 2001), being consistent with Goal Setting Theory (Locke and Latham, 2019) to make the objectives measurable and adaptable. Keeler (2020) states, mission and vision statements help businesses define their core purpose and strategic aspirations, which then lead to inform decision-making processes and align organisational efforts.

Human in Sport's mission statement:

The mission is to discover, develop and share powerful stories of the niche athletes and humanise sports through digital media, community engagement and discovering talents through AI.

Human in Sport's vision statement:

The aim is to become the world's leading platform by 2030 for uncovering the athlete stories, bringing the raw talent into the spotlight and showcasing the real struggle behind their success through inclusive storytelling, digital innovation and authentic visibility. This connects with social goals like the United Nation's efforts to promote gender equality which is essential to create chances for every talent in the sporting space (United Nations, 2023).

1.3 Aim and Objectives

The primary aim behind this business plan is to build HIS into a reputable digital storytelling platform, which elevates the voice of the niche athletes to the community of sports lovers across the globe. The objectives are based on goalsetting principles which mean that they are clear, enabling adaptation to a fast-evolving digital environment and aligning with it (Locke & Latham, 2019; Grant, 2021). As recent studies suggest, goal setting models must not only be measurable but should be adaptable inclusive and audience focused particularly under the condition of rapidly changing digital landscape (Grant, 2021).

HIS has established specific strategic goals during its development. The venture will have a multi-platform presence on YouTube, Instagram and produce podcasts with the purpose of providing athlete stories and interactive programming by 2026. By 2027, the aim is to have an online active community of 100,000 with the majority them being Gen Zs and millennials. In 2028, a minimum of 100 niche athletes to be onboarded with an aim to secure sponsorship or partnership for at least 20 of them through the platform. Funding will also be obtained by 2029 to create an AI-powered discovering tool for identifying raw talents. In 2030, the focus will be international recognition based on collaboration with NGOs, federations and global brands.

These objectives show the growing demand for authentic and inclusive storytelling in sports positioning HIS to connect audiences and fans with niche athletes (Statista 2024; Newman, 2020).

1.4 Services

HIS is a digital platform that offers inclusive and authentic storytelling and support services for niche athletes. Primarily, the platform produces and distributes multimedia content that includes short-form videos, podcast interviews and athlete branding to give the athletes visibility who are overshadowed by the mainstream sports and media.

Apart from creating content around the athletes, HIS also offers services like brand development of the athletes such as media training, personal branding and securing sponsors for the athletes. This service has the main aim to connect the talents with the exposure they deserve, thus making it easier for the athletes and the raw talents to grow both on and off the field (Gerrard, 2019). One of such innovative approach would be the AI driven talent discovery tool where the open-sourced data is analysed to bring forward the emerging athletes and tell their story to strengthen inclusivity by way of technology (Ratten, 2023).

Combining the user-generated discovery with the digital storytelling, HIS ensures it's impact is not only locally but globally relevant to the users.

1.5 Customers

HIS is a platform designed to serve two main types of customer groups. The first group would be for the raw talents, the underdog athletes, grassroots players and those in non-mainstream sports who aim for greater visibility and career opportunities. The second group are the main audience, which includes the Gen Z and the millennial audiences, who value authentic content and raw stories of the road to success

in sport. This demographic increasingly supports platforms that reflect their values and challenge conventional media narratives (Statista, 2024).

To build a loyal audience and long-term interactions, the platform will focus intensively on meaningful storytelling, active participation of the community and consistent delivery of values. As highlighted by McMullan and Gilmore (2008), customer loyalty is closely tied to emotional connection and quality service, while Oliver (1999) notes that long-term retention depends on meeting user expectations and creating repeat engagement.

1.6 Summary

This chapter has described the mission, vision, objectives, services and the target audiences of HIS where it finds its place as a solution to the lack of representation in sports media (Bruce, 2016; Newman, 2020). Based on the theory of audience centred innovation (Kotler and Keller, 2016) and brand purpose (Kaplan and Norton, 2001), the platform integrates community interactions, athlete branding, discovery of raw talents using AI and uniting the grassroots with accessing mainstream success. This chapter sets the stage for the further chapters, which will rely on primary research and market trends to shape its strategic development and further applicability.

Chapter 2: Market Research

2.1 Introduction

The focus of this chapter is directed at getting to know the target audience by conducting primary market research that is a direct continuation of the strategic situation presented in chapter 1. This study forms basis of all other aspects of the business plan that is including competitive strategy, content development and financial planning discussed in the later chapters to make sure that the decision of the HIS are explanatory. Kotler & Keller (2016) states that the most useful strategies are based on good knowledge of the need of the consumers, their desire and it is the primary research that offers the empirical foundation of sustainable growth. Accordingly, there are content consumption patterns of familiarity with niche sports, preferred storytelling design and the perceived significance of diversity in sports media, each having a straight influence on the next strategy.

The chapter also makes sure that the evidence related to the audience has become part of the bigger business narrative by placing such findings through the existing academic structure of consumer behaviour and digital media engagement (Bruce, 2016; Newman, 2020; Statista, 2024). As an example, the heavy use of Instagram and YouTube clearly justifies the digital distribution and promotion plans that have been established in Chapter 6, while the focus on inclusivity justifies the differentiation and positioning plan in Chapter 5. By doing so, the market research does not simply give information, but tells a continuous story flow underpinning the possibility, positioning and sustainability of HIS.

2.2 Research Method

To understand the consumer behaviour a quantitative survey method was chosen to have a measurable, generalised information based on a wide range of demographic population base. Quantitative research provides objectivity and can find statistically significant trends in audience

behaviour (Guo, 2013; Creswell, 2014) and at scale it allows to observe statistically significant relationships important for early stage of a venture, thus having an evidence-based approach.

An online survey was structured and was created in Microsoft forms which was used to select the format and send the survey using LinkedIn, WhatsApp and university networks as some ways that helped reaching digital active sports consumers. The survey questionnaires included multiple choices, Likert-type and ranking questions to obtain behavioural and attitudinal level of data. The questions were focused on platform usage, content preferences and perceptions about a presentation of underrated and niche athletes making sure to keep up with the inclusive nature of the platform (Bruce, 2016; Newman, 2020).

The survey was conducted in such a way that the results can be used in the overall chapters of the business plan. The perspective and vision on platforms upheld strategies in Chapter 6 and inclusivity and diversity statistics positioned in chapter 5. Based on the survey data the financial planning (Chapter 7) and the operational planning (Chapter 8) is made. SPSS was used to analyse the descriptive statistics, frequency as well as correlation giving futuristic output presented in Appendices A.

2.3 Sample

The number of participants who took part in the survey was 76 people which included athletes and non-athletes of age group 18-35. This group of people are in line with the target audience consisting of the Gen Z and millennials, a group well known for consuming digital content, socially responsible and ready to consume sports content online (Statista, 2024). The participants are combination of amateur and professional athletes, sports enthusiast and fans who are aware of the niche sports and underrated athletes.

The use of such purposive sampling method (Sharma, 2017) guaranteed the inclusion of subgroups that remain likely to connect to grassroots, minority or underrepresented athletes. This kind of targeting makes the insights more valid to elaborate on the platform characteristics and marketing strategy. The sample is also designed to indicate the consumption habit of HIS that aims at discussing through being digitally literate. The full survey is presented in Appendices A that supports the representativeness of the primary data and reinforcing it in subsequent analysis.

2.4 Survey Design and Key Findings

The survey succeeded with a balanced between finding miserable behaviour as well as getting an idea of perceptions with sports media. The use of closed ended questions facilitated statistical processing whereas the ranking of enumerated items allowed defining priorities of content types and their platform engagements. This section will narrate the main findings and will made to prove how the primary data is used to form the subsequent strategic decisions in the business plan throughout.

The level of frequency of content consumption turned out to be high, with 63% of participants consuming sports media on daily/weekly basis (Appendices A.1). Such rate underlines the importance of regular and responsive content delivery and justifies the importance of rapid production process described in Chapter 6. It also focusses on operational considerations discussed in chapter 8 where resource allocation and scheduling content depends on the existence of a stable output to meet the audience expectations.

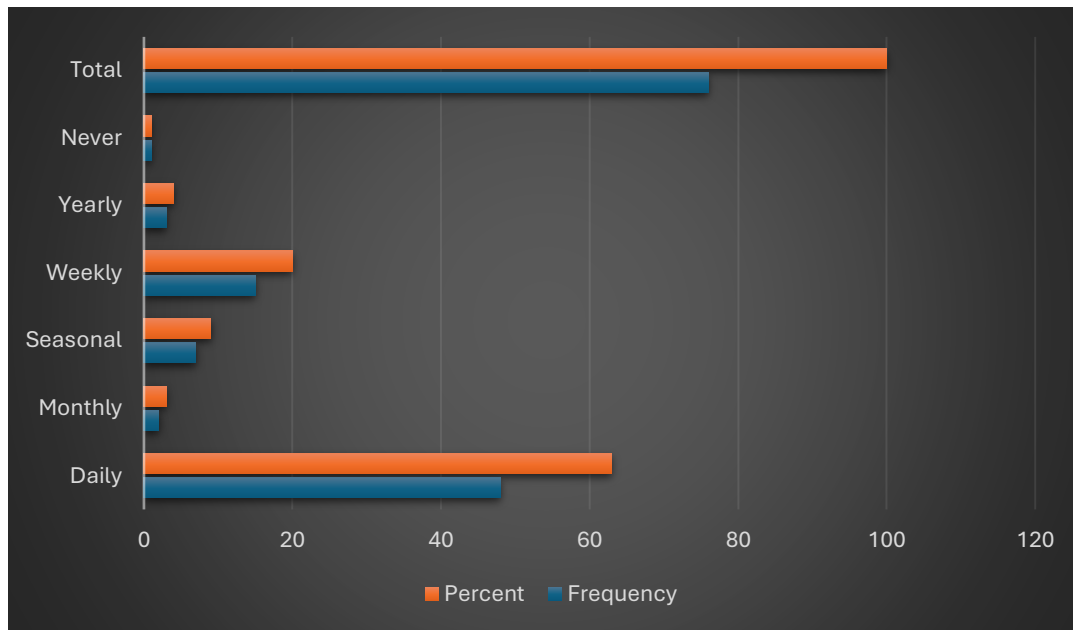


Figure 2.1: Frequency of content consumption – (Appendices A.1)

In terms of platform preferences data analysis revealed that Instagram with 52% and YouTube with 32% other top sports content consumption platforms where most of the remaining were grabbed by TikTok and Facebook. This becomes consistent with the observation made by Kemp (2024) that younger audience prefer more visual interactive contents which in turn would support the implementation of HIS to devote more platforms to present content in a visual and interactive nature that supports the IMC approach described in chapter 6, ensuring the elements of promotion are directed by platforms that will best fit the target audience behaviour.

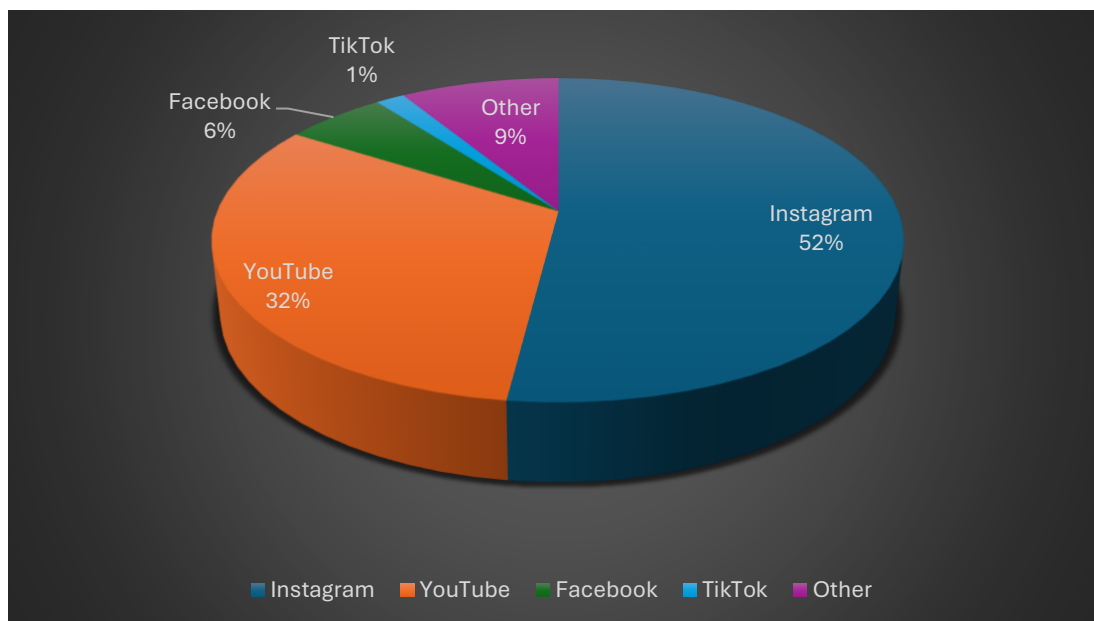


Figure 2.2: Platform Preference – (Appendices A.2)

During the survey it was seen that the awareness among the participants regarding the niche sports like futsal or para sports showed a gap in the current media coverage with 38% of the responses describing

that they were either unfamiliar or only somewhat familiar with the niche athletes while only 19% participants are the one very familiar with the niche athletes, that greatly confirm the idea that HIS is a platform geared towards inclusivity and diversity (Pegoraro & Smith, 2021).

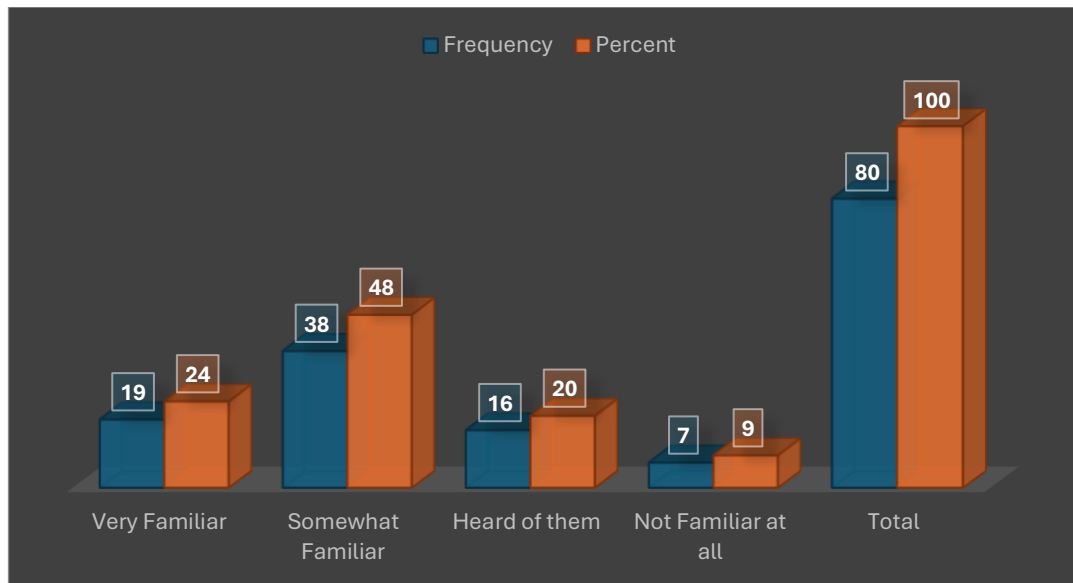


Figure 2.3: Familiarity to Niche Sports – Appendices A.3

In terms of the content preferences, the types of content revealed the match highlights (64%) are the most popular type of content and 2nd place has been taken by behind the scenes (41%) followed by motivational stories (39%). The results can be seen as an extension of industry trends at are increasingly turning towards emotionally appealing reduced size pieces that take place in the hectic reality of digital consumption (Newman, 2020; Guschwan, 2020). This fact justifies and supports the decision to develop a platform that will have the mix of content that blends entertainment with authentic storytelling justified in chapter 3 (Product & Services) and thus shape the Product Strategy in chapter 6 intended to make the product offerings meets the audience demands.

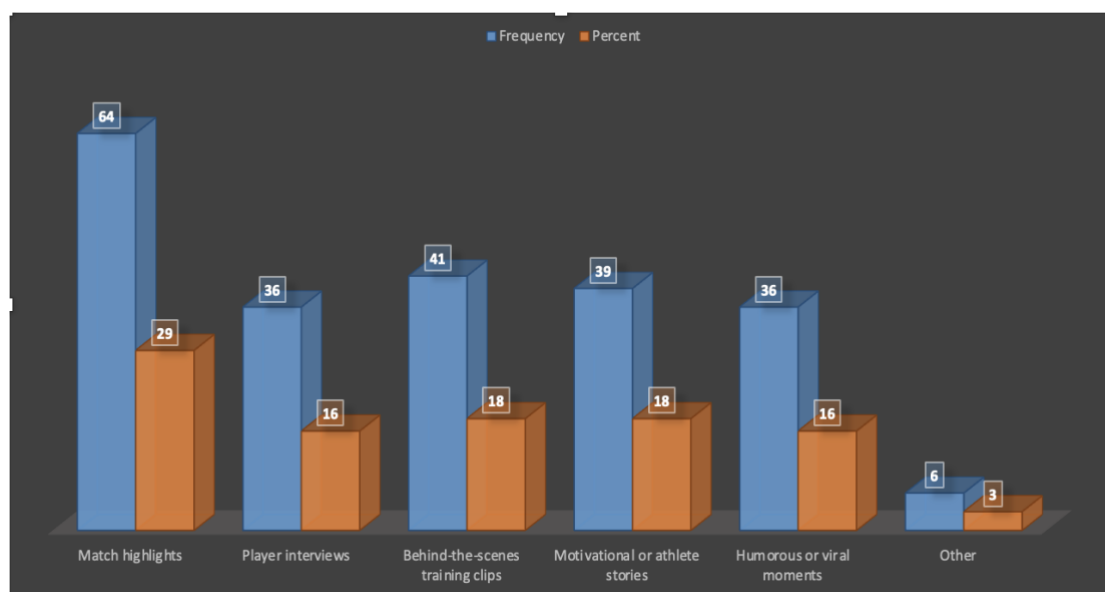


Figure 2.4 Preferred Content Types – (Appendices A.4)

The given correlation analysis served as an original confirmation of positioning off the platform. There was a statistically significant positive correlation among valuing diversity in sports media and probability of making an engagement with HIS ($r = 0.234$, $p < 0.05$) (Appendices A.5, Figure 2.5). It implies that the inclusiveness is not just a value based variable but also a predictor of consumer behaviour. This finding supports the competitive differentiation expanded within chapter 5 and brand promise emphasised in chapter 6, and the boarder financial rationale in chapter 7.

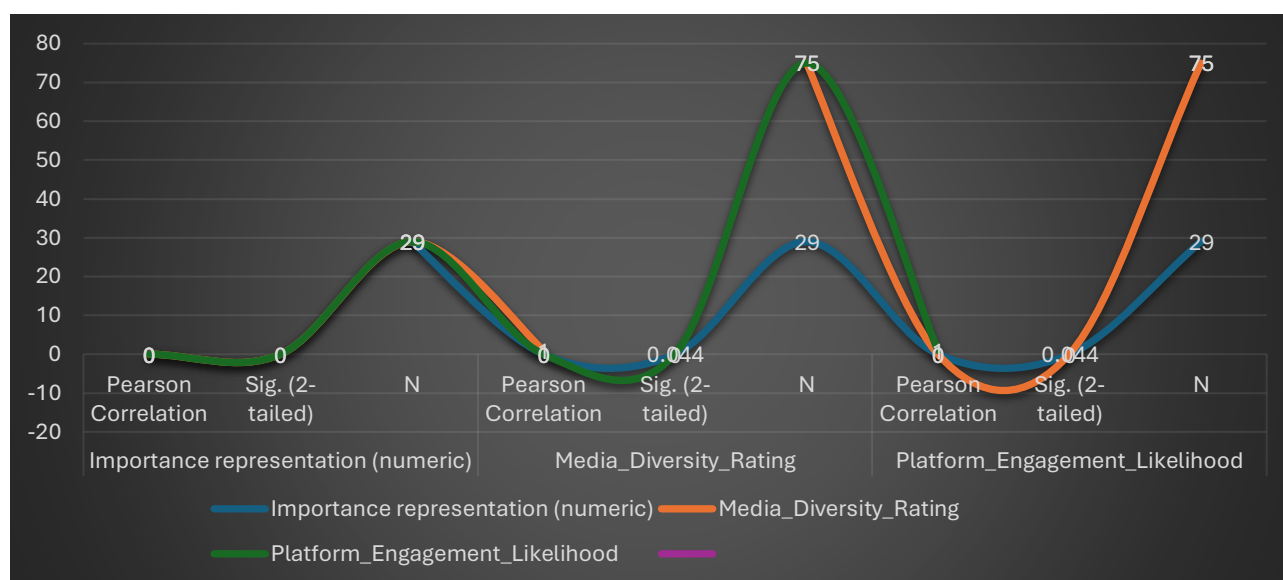


Figure 2.5: Correlations Graph. – (Appendices A.5)

2.5 Ethical Considerations and Research Limitations

Through gaining consent, the research followed the ethical standards which included transparency, voluntary participations and security of the data. Prior to going through the study, participants were made aware about the goal of the study, and they provided an explicit consent by signing a tick box agreement. The answers were anonymous and no personal information was taken without the volunteering provision of the same. Illustration of storage of data applied GDPR principles (European Union, 2018) and participants remain free to withdraw at any time. By maintaining these ethical principles, we guarded ourselves against harming participants and it had the added benefit of making the finding seem to be as credible and reliable (Bryman, 2016).

Although the conducted survey had found out a lot about the audience behaviour and preferences, some limitations were still there. The participation of 76 participants is limiting to generalisability, repeating Saunders et al. (2019) on the risk of purposive sampling and the possibility of bias in audience insights. Also, this survey did not have a straightforward indicator of desire to spend money to premium subscriptions, which implied the usage of secondary data (Statista, 2024; Nagle and Muller). Nevertheless, the findings provided an excellent platform of product development and strategy development.

Chapter 3: Products and Services

3.1 Introduction

This chapter will present the services and the features provided by HIS, that would include an inclusive digital media platform developed to promote and celebrate the niche athletes and cover the real stories about the athletes. The services are aimed at attracting attention of various audiences by means of original, emotional and ethically grounded stories. The chapter will explain the character of the platform, what benefits it will grant to the users and the athletes and discuss the unique selling point.

3.2 Service Description

The core service of HIS is storytelling which operates entirely online where content is delivered to the audience via Instagram, YouTube, Facebook, TikTok and others several digital platforms. The content includes short form videos, long form videos, athlete interview content as well as podcast episodes. Every story will be produced together with the athlete and framed by their experiences, values and identity. The platform seeks to ensure that athletes who do not receive coverage in the mainstream media can be heard by eliminating the old gatekeepers of sports broadcasting (Bruce, 2016).

The core service is storytelling which will be delivered in digital form but HIS also proposes extra service layers. Services like branded athlete packages which aids talents in creating their own brand in the form of storytelling workshop, which cultivates digital literacy and inclusion and core design merchandise which brings the narrative into tangible expression of identity. These offerings for the athletes are designed to be affordable, scalable and can be customised with varying degrees of participation while remaining aligned with the social mission of the business (Newman, 2020).

3.3 Features and Benefits

Although HIS is not selling an item, IT services is highly featured to meet both the sense of innovation and clarification. One of its main aspects is the adoption of AI assisted platform to identify new talents which opens the platform to areas outside their usual scouting conditions. This AI platform will facilitate ethical story acquisition and allow the business to expand its scale and will also focus on embracing and representing people (Ratten, 2023).

The main aspect of HIS is social media presence. Using Instagram reels, the production of YouTube shorts and to host podcast episodes the brand develops our steady base of consumers with a focus on authentic and raw athlete content. The website operates as the booking centre for the athletes, the background information and branded content. It will also offer digital storytelling workshops and one-on-one athlete services.

For the athletes, they will have digital exposure, larger audiences and possible brand partnerships. The people can find content that is both emotionally attractive and culturally engaging in the platform. The choice of this model remains consistent with emerging expectations in sports media consumption that no longer prioritise entertainment values but focus on ethical values, diversity and social connection (Keller, 2013; McKinsey & Company, 2023).

3.4 Unique Selling Point (USP)

HIS standout because its areas of ethical representation, digital innovation and community participation have been integrated into a single platform. The data in chapter 2 indicates that 64% of all the respondents argued their mainstream presentation of nice athletes were either poor or very poor and 82% of all the respondents suggested that the enhancing of the representation was extremely important. This gap has been able to substantiate Bruce (2016) argument that less than 5% sports content across the world covers women, niche or para-athletics and that establishes the business niche that the platform is serving.

The reasoning used in designing the strategy of the channel is based in chapter 2 (figure 2.2: platforms used) whereby 76% to 85% of the participants have used Instagram YouTube, and TikTok as the primary access to most sporting content which correlate with the report conducted by Statista (2024) on Gen Z and millennial habits. Niu and Wang (2016) have found that a good USP should satisfy a consumer need that is not being fulfilled, whereas according to Keller (2013), the brand resonance model states in that the loyalty can be associated with shared values an emotional relationship. The AI driven talent discovery, personal branding services and inclusive storytelling services of the platform satisfy both sets of demands: the need of the athletes (visibility, monetisation, skills) and those of the audience (authentic, representative an engaging content). This service design to audience priorities fit is direct and supported by evidence and it lies at the heart of the competitive advantage of HIS.

3.5 Summary

This chapter has described the main products and services which are provided by HIS. The platform offers more than just normal sports content. It encompasses connection, identity and purpose through AI driven athlete discovery, original content-based storytelling and delivering custom media gates with the brand. This competitive advantage of the business empowers its presence on the market and proves its intention to redefine sports media as inclusive and innovative.

Chapter 4: Size and Scale of the Market

4.1 Global Sports Market Overview

The sports market is one of the rapidly growing and most commercially valuable sectors globally. For platforms like HIS, it's important to understand that this landscape is essential to identifying the strategic opportunities. As stated by Ratten (2020), the globalisation of sports which is driven by digital media and the shift of audience expectations has created new spaces for innovations. Sport today is not just entertainment to the audience but it's a £multi-billion industry spanning media, sponsorship and merchandising (Smith and Stewart, 2015).

Over the time professional sports have generated high revenue through sports broadcasting rights and merchandising. For instance, the NFL which is one of the most viewed league in the world has secure broadcasting deals worth over \$110 billion for a ten-year period (Evens, Iosifidis, & Smith, 2013), which highlights the substantial income derived from media rights. Jaywardhana and Hartono (2018), discuss how commercialisation from broadcasting rights have become an important source of revenue for sports, especially in the English Premier League. In the same way merchandising has also played an important role where the merchandising sales are projected to increase annually and reaching \$54.6 billion by 2035. These revenue streams have played an important role in shaping the financial

landscape of professional sports globally. O'Reilly et al. (2015) has identified key factors influencing merchandise sales that include fans satisfaction, media exposure and brand strength which highlights the importance of strategic brand management in maximising the revenue of merchandise.

4.2 Addressable Niche: Underrepresented Athletes

Although there is a scale of global industry of sports, there is still a huge gap for the athletes of the niche sports when it comes to mainstream media attention. The grassroots players, raw talents and the athletes in non-traditional sports often struggle for exposure and commercial support. Bruce (2016) highlights that women and underdog athletes receive less than 5% of media coverage which shows a clear bias in representation. Newman (2020) further argues about the growing demand of authentic and athlete driven stories particularly among the young fans value raw and inspiring stories. HIS aims to build a platform that meets this need that will celebrate and overlook voices and connect them with the audience through digital storytelling.

4.3 Digital Media and Storytelling Demand

The consumption of sports is rapidly changing in present day. Audiences are moving from traditional broadcasting to digital, especially the young generation favour and support short-form videos, digital storytelling and value driven content. According to Statista (2024), the young audience that is over 70% supports and enjoy platform that highlights real-life stories and celebrates unsung heroes and inclusive representation. This shift has boost the rise and athlete-led and socially conscious media formats. As explained by Jenkins (2006), The convergence of digital media and participatory culture has helped forming new form of storytelling that encourages creators and audiences alike. HIS is positioned to tap into this trend and it will be done by delivering emotionally engaging content that will speak to both individual identity and community values.

4.4 Strategic Implications

Now by including insights from global sports economy, digital media innovation and social inclusion programs, the Total Addressable Market for HIS go beyond a traditional audience. HIS is well placed in the 100 billion economy of creators (Influencer Marketing Hub, 2023) and the growing sponsorship market of sports. This increasingly favours purpose-driven partnerships and can be supported by Keller's (2013) Brand Equity Theory, that focuses on value of authenticity and emotional resonance in building strong consumer brand relations. This is specially seen in markets that value and identify influence buying decisions.

Another instance is given by the theory of Cultural Production (Bourdieu, 1993); that explains that when major narratives, such as those involving underrepresented athletes, are conveyed by a platform, they can acquire a symbolic value to break old hierarchies of sportspersons. Giving consumers value that other content creators are unable to generate because they lack authentic narration, HIS is filling a gap in the oversaturated content market of the target market and produces an entirely new value.

These can be reinforced by the objectives and service model as defined In Chapter1 which is scalable as well as strategically fitting. Since more of the audiences start becoming closer and closer to brands that can represent their identity and overall ethics (McKinsey and Company, 2023), HIS is not just a business idea but a cultural one. The idea of representation, community engagement, and -first storytelling is the power of HIS that makes the project gain the competitive advantage and remain relevant in the long run.

4.5 Summary

This chapter will help us explore the external environment and the competitive forces influencing HIS by using strategic tools to look at and access both opportunities and threats. A good combination of PESTLE analysis, Porter's Five Forces (Porter, 2008), Blue Ocean Strategy, and the Ansoff Matrix (Ansoff, 1957) that will provide a structured view of market condition and the potential growth.

Chapter 5: Environmental and Competitive Analysis

5.1 Introduction

Following on from market size and market demand understanding, this chapter examines the environmental and competitive situation for HIS (Appendices B). It contains an in-depth PESTLE analysis, Porter's Five Forces analysis, Blue Ocean approach, Ansoff Matrix, and a review of the entrepreneurial strengths upon which the venture is based. All these assessments give a clear overview of the macro-environment and assist in the recognition of the organisation's strategic positioning in a competitive market.

5.2 PESTLE Analysis

The PESTLE model is an analytical tool used by companies to track the external environment before launching a product or service (Akman, 2020). It evaluates the political, economic, social, technological, environmental, and legal factors that may impact a business, which is where the model acronym comes from (Rastogi & Trivedi, 2016). PESTLE analysis allows a business to proactively adapt to an ever-changing environment, which is widely used in the business world by practitioners to develop future strategy plans (Tan et al., 2012). See (Appendices B.1).

The PESTLE analysis shows that HIS operates in a macro environment increasingly aligned with its mission. From favourable governmental policies to the shifting of consumer expectations and enhancement of technology, the external factors present both opportunity and responsibility. As stated by Johnson, Scholes and Whittington (2017), the key to achieving this strategic fit and long-term visibility is by properly understanding these external forces. These insights thus provide a strong foundation for the competitive analysis.

5.3 Porter's Five Forces

The Porter's Five Forces (Appendices B.2) model has been one of the most influential frameworks and most widely used tool in strategic management that offers a structured way to access the competitive pressure within an industry (Grundy, 2006). The model is shaped around the central forces, competitive rivalry, which determine the major opposing players in the industry. The other four components of the model are threat to new entrants, threat of substitutes, bargaining power of suppliers and bargaining power of buyers (Dobbs, 2014). The threat of the new entrants in the industry depends on how other enter the digital media space easily while the threat of the substitutes identifies product and services in the industry which can fulfil the same purpose and compete (Bruijil and Gerard, 2018). The bargaining power of the supplier and buyers are dependent on their level of power as they have the ability to influence and change each other's control of the industry (Pringle and Huisman, 2011).

Competitive pressure on HIS may be balanced through paying attention to the underserved market, yet the rivalry-driven focus of the Porters (2008) and the non-competitive space focus of the Blue Oceans

(Kin and Mauborgne, 2015) need to be made to reconcile. As suggested by Porter (2008), the strategic positioning and the differentiation are the key to reducing the impact of industry forces. By regularly innovating the content strategy and building emotional engagement with valuable audience, the platform thus strengthens brand loyalty and reduce the openness to offerings to the rivals (Keller, 2013).

5.4 Blue Ocean Strategy

As stated by (Kim and Mauborgne, 2015), the Blue Ocean Strategy (Appendices B.3) encourages creating new demands in the untouched and less explored market rather than competing in the saturated and well-established market. This is a key for HIS, which upfront challenges the famous and celebrity-driven sports media by giving importance to niche sports. The venture applies the four actions framework that eliminates the outdated narratives, reducing the high cost of media, rising visibility and creating raw and inclusive content with actual emotions. This well align with the strategic innovation theory stated by (Govindarajan and Trimble, 2010) which shows how breaking industry norms and going out of the box can shame new and loyal consumer behaviour. By leveraging AI and community engagement, HIS refines the values and impact in today's digital era.

By using Blue Ocean Strategy, HIS do not position itself in direct competition with the big players like the legacy broadcasters or the dominating OTT platforms, but it positions itself as a mission-driven innovator functioning in a new and well-defined space (Kim and Mauborgne, 2015). By going out of the box and beyond conventional metrics like viewership and sponsorship, it defines its success criteria which defines its visibility, authenticity and social impact. This reflects value innovation where strategic success stems from redefining market boundaries rather than competing and challenging the rivals. The platform focus on inclusivity and storytelling led by the community that also aligns with purpose-driven branding (Kotler et al. 2019), that shows how differentiation and mission can converge to create long term strategic relevance.

5.5 The Ansoff Matrix

The Ansoff Matrix (Ansoff, 1957), in (Appendices B.4) offers a strategic planning tool through which HIS will be able to explore growth while staying true and focused to its mission. By examining opportunities to penetrate in the market, development of the product, market development and diversification, the platform will be able to scale its reach and offerings without compromising the core values of inclusivity and representation. This well-structured approach supports the organisation in both innovation and risk management, especially in this rapidly growing digital space. As Johnson, Scholes and Whittington (2017) argue, this type of tool is important and vital for aligning innovation led by purpose with long-term strategy, enabling ventures like HIS to grow sustainably while deepening their social impact.

This model of Ansoff Matrix provides a valuable framework that highlights how HIS pursue sustainable growth while staying focused and rooted in its mission (Ansoff, 1957). But exploring pathways such as the penetration in the market, innovation of product, regional expansion and social impact of the diversification, the platform gets to balance innovation along with ethical scaling. The strategic alignment helps manage risk and reinforces the inclusive commitment, core digital storytelling. As Johnson, Scholes and Whittington (2017) states and highlights, growth strategies are majorly effective when they reflect core values of the organisation and respond to the organisation's external environment. This foundation sets the stage for examining how entrepreneurial traits can further supports the evolution of the platform.

4.6 Summary

This chapter has critically examined the strategic environment surrounding of HIS by using the PESTLE analysis (Johnson et al., 2017), Porter's Five Forces (Porter, 2008) and Blue Ocean Strategy (Kim and Mauborgne, 2015) that highlight a market prime for disruption through inclusive, value-added storytelling. The Ansoff Matrix (Ansoff, 1957) further illustrated how the platform can scale responsibly by aligning growth strategies with its mission. Central to this is a foundation of entrepreneurial traits, a vision, innovation and social purpose that has enhances the ventures feasibility and resilience (Shane and Venkataraman, 2000). Collectively, these insights position HIS as a strategically grounded, a social conscious business with the potential to rephrase digital sports media globally. The next chapter will explore how target marketing strategies can active and sustain meaningful audience engagement.

Chapter 6: Marketing

6.1 Introduction

The marketing plan of HIS conveys the mission of the platform as the authentic, inclusive, athlete centric storytelling into a detailed action planning using both primary and secondary education sources. The sports media market is associated with intense rivalry among market players who contend to capture the attention of the viewers, and a reliable structure of a strategy is needed to convert brand vision into long term audience spendings and business profitability (Kotler & Keller, 2022). This chapter is an extension of the market analysis and positioning turn in previous chapter operationalising differentiation of brands using the Marketing Mix (7Ps) framework, Integrated Marketing Communications (IMC) framework and contemporary framework of digital marketing.

The Combination of these approaches demonstrates the dual character of HIS as a media resource and a service oriented on communities. The Marketing Mix (Booms & Bitner, 1981) provide a full-blown framework to bridge the gap between the product offering and the expectations of the audiences whereas, IMC provides a framework to address the audience with the same message across touchpoints (Schultz & Kitchen, 2000). The models of digital engagement like the RACE framework by Chaffey (2020) offer a data guided road map of targeting the audience in terms of acquisition, conversation and engagement in the dynamically changing digital space. Each aspect of the plan is supported by the results of the primary survey which demonstrate at 52% of the participants select Instagram 32% chose YouTube and 64% consume sports content on a daily or weekly basis and also the majority embrace representation of niche athletes.

6.2 Understanding the Market and Consumer Behaviour

The theory of market segmentation focuses on the relevance of adapting the offer to particular groups of people in order to maximise their interests (Smith, 2020). The main target audience of sports digitally is considered to be Gen Z and millennial consumers aged between 18 to 35 years who have been known to be extremely active on social media, preferring short form videos and aligned to socially responsible brand cultures (Keller, 2016). Search tendencies at a firm by primary research findings and show a strong tendency to Instagram and YouTube as the most popular platform preferences and her leaning towards visual and interactive and emotionally appealing content.

The habit of consumption of the audience draws another possibility to engage with their audience regularly as 64% of the participants watch sports content every day or several times a week and match

highlights 29%, behind the scenes videos 18% and inspirational stories 18% were among the most popular type of content. In addition, most participants prioritised diversity and representation within sports media which indicates lack of resources in the available market where niche athletes would not get much coverage.

From the psychographic perspective, the target group describes the value of authenticity, inclusivity an active engagement. Such characteristics are consistent with the studies which have associated purposeful branding with enhanced consumer loyalty (Kotler & Keller, 2022). The secondary target audience is NGOs, federations, grassroots sports clubs and brands looking to sponsor niche and underrated athletes to demonstrate some form of social responsibility. Identification of such behavioural and attitudinal motivators would make the market strategy meet the needs of the audience as well as partner expectations.

6.3 Market Positioning

Positioning means establishing a probable special perception, which should be credible and memorable in the mind of the target audience (Aaker & Shansby, 1982). HIS is a project that is clearly against to the subject matter of the mainstream sports media, which gives more attention to major sports events and athletes who are already famous in the market. Rather, the value proposition of the brand is centred in the concept of offering athletics focused & community driven narratives that present talent in grassroots, para sports, niche sports and raw talents.

The strategy of this project reflects the principle of the Blue Ocean Strategy that we discussed in chapter 5, which advocates about the creation of uncontested market space through unique value propositions instead of struggling to win the war in the cluttered market. According to the competitive analysis in chapter 4, revealed that major sports media players are focused on scale and immediacy, which creates an opportunity to introduce platforms having more depth, authenticity and social impact issues.

The use of the primary survey data gives perpetual mapping placing HIS within one of the quadrants of high authenticity and high interaction with the audience, a quadrant that is underrepresented. The placing of the niche athletes and their stories at 72% priorities confirmed such positioning with a high level of market suitability of the content that transcend commercial sports storytelling.

6.4 The Marketing Mix (7Ps)

6.4.1 Product Strategy: Delivering Authentic Value

According to the theory of marketing, the product is most important which represents the core value offering, encompassing both the tangible and intangible benefits (Kotler & Keller, 2022). In the case of HIS, the product is a mix of the content formats which are the short form videos, in depth interviews, podcast and feature articles which are designed to deliver functional value (sports entertainment, news) an emotional value (inspiration, connection, representation).

The primary research data directly informed this mix where the match highlights with 29%, stories behind the scenes 18% and motivational stories with 18% will be used as a regular supply of content, whereas A thematic series of motivational stories will use these sources. The process of differentiation will be also attend using the AI based athlete discovery tool, which will recognise the upcoming raw

talent based on the community input and digital data analytics. The innovation is in line with the brand equity model employed by Keller (2016), where the key message is the provision of the performance related and imagery value drivers.

6.4.2 Pricing Strategy: Balancing Accessibility and Sustainability

The Ability of digital services pricing to inclusively meet needs versus generating revenue should be balanced (Nagle & Muller, 2018). The freemium model will be adapted for this business where the core content will be always free with paid subscriptions adding the operation to earlier access to the content, longer interviews and interactive opportunities and special events.

The primary data suggest that premium engagement has a higher potential and access to the behind the scenes, as well as a deeper athlete story is appreciated by 18% and 18% of respondents respectively. The diversification of its revenue will feature brand material and sponsorship deals as well as merchandise sales which fits into the principle suggested by Booms and Bitner's (1981) service marketing that various sources of revenue can take root of the price sensitivity in the respective customer groups.

6.4.3 Place Strategy: Maximising Reach Through Hybrid Channels

The Channel used to distribute information should be in conjunction with the audience behaviour (Chaffey & Ellis-Chadwick, 2019). The priority in digital first delivery will be Instagram with 52% with and YouTube with 32% with the video marketing, Spotify with the audio podcasts and the brand side with long form article and community features. Partnerships with the grassroots sports events, NGOs and education institutions will be entered to build offline presence.

The hybrid strategy achieves the characteristics of both breadth and depth of reach where the digital channel reaches the mass audience and offline experiences builds a deeper trust. This complies with the model of omnichannel strategy developed by Verhoef et al. (2015) Whose traces to consider consistency and complementary between physical and digital touchpoints.

Since the audience prefer to use Instagram and YouTube and the brands falls into the high authenticity space and high interactions, the strategy of promotion will be implemented through the combination of these channels as a constituent part of the multi-channel plan. The goal is to create a conversation, established community, create an emotional response and tie the experience together so every touch point of social media, live events etc reinforce the brand promise. By matching the activities of the promotion with the value proposition and behavioural pattern as obtained in the primary research, HIS will be able to have reach as well as resonance.

6.4.4 Promotion Strategy: Integrated Marketing Communications (IMC)

Based on its universal application, HIS promotes its advertising campaign on the promise of Integrated Marketing Communications (IMC) (Schultz & Kitchen, 2000), which is based on the idea that consistency and synergies of messages needs reinforcements across various media used in the case with intendant effects must be enhanced. In the case of digital first sports storytelling platform, IMC can provide a process to make sure that all the audience engagements (via a short Instagram reel, a

podcast episode, even an in person meet up of the athletes) remind the audience that the promise of the brand is the “Real stories of the Real athletes”.

This will be executed using the RACE model developed by Chaffey (2020), Which coordinates the promotional journey to the full phase of reach, act, convert and engage. The reach stage will encompass using Instagram and YouTube (the two platforms used by 84% of the survey participants) to conduct targeted advertising and implement SEO apply to all the content posted on the web resource, to attract the attention of an audience eager to consume content related to niche sports. This act is aimed to engage audience by means of interactive materials like polls, questions & answers with athletes, challenges to create stories by participants. The web platform is going to be targeted at younger populations, which had been determined during the primary research who are socially and environmentally conscious.

The convert stage will focus on the clear call-to-actions which will result in either premium subscriptions or participations in events. In another example behind the scenes footage weather premium resources valued by majority of respondents will be framed as a special treat to incentivise conversation. Lastly engage will maintain loyalty via personalised community updates, newsletters to subscribers, gamified elements of the AI power athlete discovery tool.

Every channel of communication is assigned a specific role in this combined solution. Digital arising will provide a high level of audience targeting based on age, the physical location an interest in niche sports so that the media spend is focused on relevancy (Blech & Belch, 2021). The authenticity of the brand and the fact that it will support the theory of brand equity elaborated by Keller (2016) ask content marketing establishment of emotional connection with the brand through constant publications written by athletes, blog by athletes and short documentaries created by athletes. Social proof as promoted by influential partnerships, especially associated athletes and micro influencers will be used to grow scope and deepen trust (Cialdini, 2007).

Offline activities become an important addition to online actions. Example of the online engagement being turned into real an unforgettable experience through experiential marketing includes pop-up screening, community sports skins and meet and greet with their favourite athletes which will create even your emotional connection (Pine & Gilmore, 1998). The PR Practise will aim to have coverage on the sports focused lifestyle powered, and community-oriented media to gain greater credibility and extend beyond the reach of the current digital audience.

The KPIs corresponding to each of RACE stages will be monitored as the effectiveness of cost per reach, engagement rate, click through rate, conversion rate, growth of the subscribers and Net Promoter score. The frequent checkup will allow making interactive adjustments to keep campaigns in line with the audience behavioural pattern and market conditions. This integrated approach is further operationalised by the social media content plan (see Appendices C) and the supporting Gantt Chart (see Appendices D.1) that offer discipline framework of regular and evidence-based delivery. The allocated budget for marketing is also presented (Appendices D.2) which is in accordance with financial plan (Chapter 7) which helps in advancement between strategic purpose and economic visibility ensuring feasibility.

6.4.5 People Strategy: Building Human Capital

The people comprise service aspects of marketing as you have every individual curating the customer experience (Zeithaml et al., 2018). HIS offers job postings in storytelling, videographers, social media managers, graphic designers, editors and athlete liaisons who reflect inclusivity and authenticity values of the brand.

Co production of athlete partnerships will also be applied to make sure the narratives are based on their life experiences. When using a SERVQUAL dimensions (Parasuraman et al., 1988), It will be focused on reliability, empathy, assurance and responsiveness.

6.4.6 Process Strategy: Delivering Consistency and Agility

The processes will be made agile so that they can adapt the changing developments in sports stories without compromising on quality productions. The graphics will require ideations with audience insights, multiplatform content creation and distribution, engagement an analytical review of the workflow.

The necessity of the rapid content cycle is confirmed by survey evidence that 63% of consumption is carried out in several times per week. With the service blueprinting (Zeithaml et al., 2020), It will be possible to isolate the bottlenecks and streamline the experiences of audiences at every part of the touchpoint.

6.4.7 Physical Evidence: Strengthening Tangible Brand Cues

The tangible evidence supports the audiences when they are concerned with the quality and professionalism of the service (Booms and Bitner, 1981). In the case of HIS, it comprises a visually coherent identity, well produced high quality production, branded athlete kit and a well-designed, professional mobile friendly website.

Backstage material and testimony will be used as symbolic evidence towards a genuine feel and is in line with the signalling theory, which states that tangible devices help build trust in intangible services (Spence, 1973).

6.5 Summary

The marketing strategy of HIS is based on the concept of operationalising its positioning in the market and the mission of the company through the integration of the 7Ps, IMC model and digital engagement model. This strategy is based on every aspect on primary data as well as on the academic theory, thus making sure all portions of brand values, audience experiences and commercial objectives are not misaligned. Critical reflections acknowledge the insufficiencies of classical pattern in dynamic digital context therefore requiring flexibility of performance and continuous feedback.

The multi-dimensional strategy will enable HIS to gain sustainable development, enhancing engagement with audience and give voice to underrepresented and the niche athletes both locally and globally.

Chapter 7: Financial Plan

7.1 Introduction

The HIS financial plan is the synthesis of the evidence is and strategic thoughts which are elaborated during the previous chapters of this business plan. Chapter 2 defined consumer demand which consisted of storytelling of athletes whereas chapter 3 provided a list of products and services that could satisfy this demand. Stepped forward has discussed the external environment and found both limitations and opportunities in sports media environment and chapter 6 has described integrated marketing communications strategy. Considering all these chapters, it provides a foundation upon which the business financial design will be constructed.

Financial planning must not be an isolated calculation as Kaplan and Norton (1996) states that it should serve as the bridge between the areas of the mission, operational and quantifiable results and the approach here is shaped in this principle. HIS is not a purely commercial project rather it has a mission behind it which is the inclusiveness and authentic representation. The financial plan is thus meant to balance the two objectives which include ensuring the platform is able to reach a financial sustainability and inculcate the values in all aspects of revenue generation and expenditure.

7.2 Sources of Finance and Funding

One of the greatest challenges facing early-stage venture is to secure dependable and diversified funding. Burns (2016) emphasise that inappropriate financial support or excessive financial concentration is one of the key reasons of start of failure and Atrill and McLaney (2019) note that funding structures should correspond to the strategic goals. In the case of HIS, the financing model has thus been designed specifically to minimise relative reliance on founder equity and to gain strength with a blended portfolio of sources.

One of such approach is business angel investment that offers liquidity but introduces risk of equity dilution risks, reflecting Burns (2016) on fragility of venture. In the UK, angel activity is warmly received in the creative and digital industries and the UK Business Angels Association (2023) found that at typical early-stage deals involves investors purchasing 10 to 20 percent of equity. These have not only cash injects but access to contacts and experience, which can be especially handy to new venture that is trying to expand into the competitive sports media landscape. What Angel finance does do raise however is the issue of equity dilution. (Appendices E.1) shows three options: raising £50,000 in exchange of a 10% stake is a preservation strategy that maintains founder control and exchange the cash run runway. Then raising £100,000 in exchange of a 20% share that shows speedy growth but reduces long term autonomy and raising £150,000 in exchange for 30% share is a buyer that offer short term security at the expense of strategic free will in case more funds are needed. It is on this ground that the financial plan proposals are modest equity sharing at the lower and office scale to balance between ambition with governance.

7.3 Cash Flow and Break-Even Analysis (Year 1)

Start-ups are highly dependent on cash flow as a survival factor and the structure of HIS during its first year is the normal trend of venture. The initial heavy deficit at the beginning of the year is shown in the table below (refer to Appendices E.2) the expenses to create and market the content are highest at the

time of launch. This alliance with arms of the IMC strategy in chapter 6, that shows awareness of early investment in the Instagram and YouTube to gain reach and credibility.

7.4 Revenue Model and Growth Assumptions

HIS revenue model is planned in such a way that no individual revenue stream would predominate and cause high risk coverage. During the initially other revenues will be mainly generated through sponsorship and advanced subscriptions. This is consistent with the respondents coordinating willingness to consume untold stories content in chapter 2 and fits the priorities of the IMC in chapter 6 that emphasises the early digital reach. These inflows are complemented by crowdfunding and grants and because they do not require significant cash outlay contra agreements with community partners offset early overheads.

In the second year, the model will be diversified with the introduction of merchandise and ticketed events. This growth is directly in reaction of market evidence content in chapter 2 where audiences were shown to have an interest in both physical athletes' affiliation with the fans as well as the ability to interact with athletes in real life environments. It is also justified by the broader trends in the industry: (Statista, 2024) predicts the that 7% yearly growth in the field sales of sports items across the globe, and (Deloitte, 2023) focuses on the increasing popularity of the experiential events associated with fans. These additions will not only increase revenue, but the brand equity will also be greater as HIS is going deeper in roots in the community.

Since the third year, the branded content association will become more considerable. The partnership of COPA90 with UEFA establish a precedent of scalability of the storytelling-based partnership (Draper, 2020). Such experiential strategy will decrease the over dependence on one type of income and set the platform to lasting growth. The recurrent subscribing an event will form most part of income by the fifth year and sponsorships are restructured as a booster but not a lifeline. The revenue projections are given in detail and have the gross margin assumption assumed on a stream-by-stream basis, as shown in (Appendices E.3).

7.5 Expenditure Structure and Justification

The HIS expenditure profile portrays strategic priorities as well as the evidence base that has been laid in the previous chapters. Fixed operating budget allocation is presented in (Appendices E.4) over 5 years, the reasoning behind this allocation is also clear that highest amount will go to the production of the content itself, and this is the thinking based on chapter 2 survey data where 47% of the respondents thought that highlight an athlete led storytelling was the top choice. The value creation of the platform is centred on content (chapter 3) and is the basis of marketing performance discussed in (chapter 6). Investment in equipment, editing and creative support are hence considered as foundation and not discretionary cost. The second largest segment is the marketing and public relations which comes out of IMC strategy. As Instagram, YouTube becomes main sport content consumption platform, the resources are devoted to specific digital advertising and influencer programmes. The practice aligns with findings by (Deloitte, 2023) in the industry space involving identification of digital first as the best pathway towards growth in the audience.

7.6 Five-Year Financial Outlook

The five-year HIS financial projection shows how in a slow gradual way, the firm is coming out of the proof of concept and into the framework of sustainable profitability. The proposed revenues have been outlined in (Appendices E.3) as follows: in year 1 the company will make sales of £36,000 and in year 5, the sales will reach an amount of £107,000. The initial year is deliberately negative, where a significant level of marketing and content spending is to be made to figure in establishing visibility that describe the J-curve in entrepreneurial finance (Kaplan & Strömberg, 2003). This is early investment, and this is the line when the IMC approach undertaken in chapter 6, in Chapter 2 evidence indicated a high demand of authentic storytelling stations. Even though this investment results in the business closing the year in a deficit, what is expected to be funded is deficit in terms of angel investment, grants and sponsorship inflows thus the risk is being predicted and addressed.

In second year, the model get solid as revenue gets diversified. Along with the increased subscription, merchandise and events are introduced generating the influence of the changes in the total of 60,000. The choice to invest in such streams is supported by the chapter 2 survey evidence and industry rate offered by Statista (2024) and Deloitte (2023) as the merchandise and experience-based fan activations were proved to be the areas of growth within the scope of the sports industry in general. The revenues of sponsorship are also stable during this month as their shift between opportunistic early deals to much formalised relationships. The break-even point remains at year three, when revenue equalise at £72,500 the business will be at break-even supported by recurring digital revenues and recurring sponsorship renewal.

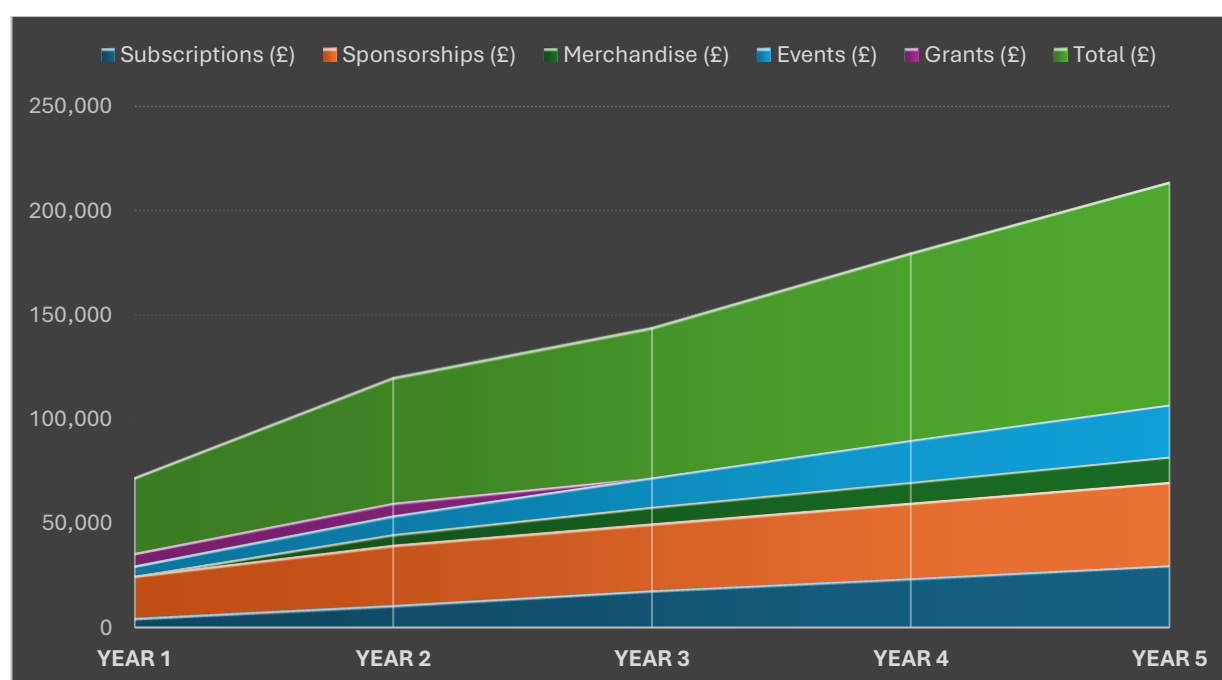


Figure 7.1: Revenue Mix Evolution (Years 1–5) – Appendices E.5
Source: Statista (2024) and Deloitte (2023).

7.7 Projected Balance Sheet

The balance sheet showed in (Appendices E.6) which is aimed at demonstrating investment in HIS is based on the controlled and incremental approach to growth as described in previous sections. The

assets are concentrated in equipment, softwares and intangible assets in the form of brands and intellectual premises in the form of equipment during the starting years. Such investments are in line with the focus on high value content and online infrastructure which serves as the foundation of service model of the platform discussed in chapter 3. The liabilities continued to be deliberately kept low, with a major part of the small start-up loans and deferred sponsor agreements, which fits in the scale of the operations. Supporting equality in this phase is supported by the founder commitment as well as by the angel investment, sponsorship linked finance and grants in section 7.2. This is combined strategy such that the venture does not become over debted and builds a framework that aligns with both mission and the market realities.

As the venture matures beyond three to five years, the balance sheet has a gradual rise showing off a slowed equity and retained earnings. Darren gradual increases in the cash reserves which is due to the increase seen in the contribution of recurring revenues due to subscriptions and events and also the rise in the amount of accounts receivable with the increase in the renewal of sponsorship and events. Significantly, intangible assets are to be conservatory recognised at the cost during the initial two years, as invoked by Drury(2013), however during the third year the income-based system under IAS 38 would be relatively more appropriate since its acknowledges potential of generating earnings by the brand in the future. The development is not only the shift of HIS operating which depends on external financing, but also a business which with an independent financial basis able to promote regional growth rising and which pretends long term credibility on the part of investors.

7.8 Risk Management and Financial Sustainability

Financial planning does not require only an estimate of the two revenue lines as well as in the spending curves but the crystal-clear identification of risk that may well destroy them. The HIS case has boiling threats of funding shortfall, platform dependency, legal disputes, audience stagnation, and reputational risk (Appendices E.7). They are counteracted by mindful income stream diversification in such a way that the business does not restore to excessive reliance on sponsorship like with OTRO (Financial Times, 2020). Offloading production activity and relying on contra agreement contain the cost, with liquidity being protected by holding a three-month operating expenditure reserve. Such a buffer will also ensure that the operations are not disrupted when temporary shortage occur on the money table, and this is well stated in the entrepreneurial finance literature (Atrill & McLaney, 2019)

Together with these, sustainability is also achieved through applying moral filters to revenue creations. Sponsorships must be checked to be in line with the purpose of the venture of inclusivity and empowerment, which like Ratten (2023) recommend sports entrepreneurship to be financially and socially balanced. Key performance indicators are used to track progress and include subscription churn rate, average revenue per user, percentage renewal sponsored and event ROI. Such indicators constitute a balance scorecard of performance (Kaplan and Norton 1996) that enables the management to keep track of both the financial performance stability and the mission achievement. HIS builds not only a road to profitability, but also a system of long-term sustainability and integrity by building a combination position between conservative financial protection with one side and ethical and mission driven practises on the other.

7.9 Rationale for the Financial Plan

The financial plan is realistic and has also been precised to be in tandem with the mission of HIS. The model gives start-ups an angel investment divided with innovation grants, sponsorship-based equity

as well as contra agreement along with other aspects thus preventing over dependence on an initial risk capital, which widely determent to startups (Burns, 2016). Every aspect of this strategy is best on the evidence like the subscription model and sustainability by both the survey conducted in chapter 2, its marketing investment being with IMC framework in chapter 6 and the operational and technology presents its value based on the product breakthrough in chapter 3, as well as the technological motivations identified in chapter 4. By doing so a necessary relationship is developed between the prior analysis of the business and the financial plan, and in this manner the financial plan as a whole entity is not an isolated exercise but rather a continuity based on previous analysis.

It is also important to balance the ambition and sustainability. The protection of the laws over five years demonstrates their loss make Ripley decrease during the first year of launch, however after this. Everything is balanced answer plus after the three years regularly which is indeed similar to the trends provided by PwC (2023) regarding the digital media entrepreneurship. Equity dilution cases (Appendices E.1) are added in such a way that the trade-offs between capital raised and controlled by founders are thoroughly considered, visual summarises in (Figure 7.2, Appendices E.8) helps to understand that dependence on sponsorship is dependent on the number of subscriptions and events.

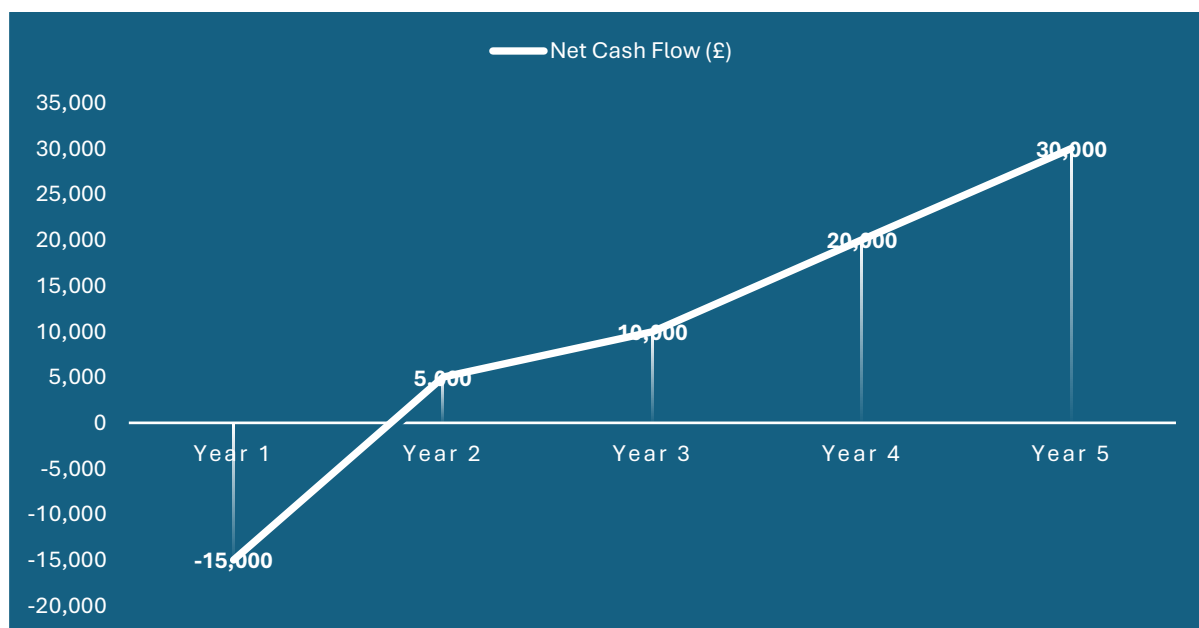


Figure 7.2: Net Cash Flow (Years 1–5) – (Appendices E.8)
Source: Atrill & McLaney (2019); Deloitte (2023).

Chapter 8: Implementation, Operations & Evaluation

8.1 Introduction

This chapter puts the Chapter 7 financial plan into operational practise. It gives a road map on how HIS will be run in year 1 where resources are most restricted, and decisions are most critical before giving a projection of how operations will grow from year 2 to 5. It also lays in the controversy of evaluation and controls necessary to measure progress and goal assurance. Implementation, in its most primitive form is not merely about efficiency but also about values that HIS have a mission of empowering

athletes based on authentic and inclusive storytelling and a vision to become a community centred trusted sports media platform. These questions can also be regarded as guides in the whole chapter and that defined the way operation should be organised and evaluated.

8.2 Implementation in Year 1

Year 1 will be the foundation of HIS having an organised nimble structure encompassing the content production, marketing, partnership and operations along with finance (Appendices F). This reflects the efficiency of startups in terms of resources (Burns, 2016) and it agreed with the budget priorities introduced in Chapter 7. The content production supports the interest of the primary data in chapter 2 that revealed that 29% of survey participants valued highlights and 18% to athlete's stories and through digital campaigns on Instagram and YouTube ensures early engagement with audiences and this analysis would be consistent with the overall effect that digital first consumption has on sports media (Deloitte, 2023). Based on this discussion of sponsorship on grassroots and socially oriented brands, the theory by Ratten (2023) that early legitimacy in sports entrepreneurship is constructed most efficiently by value-based collaborations.

In the first year the risks involved are higher. The dependence on freelancers can also influence quality control and insufficient availability of the staff can cause marketing bottlenecks that align with the reports on lean capabilities of startups (Ries, 2011). The organisation may also have a slower time in securing the sponsorship income in comparison to the forecast which compounds cashflow strains in SME finance research (Atrill & McLaney 2019). On top of that the existence of external dependencies increases its vulnerability that the visibility will change with the changes in the algorithms of these social media (Statista 2024), and the utilised third-party hosting services are also spectacle to the fluctuations of services or cost (PwC, 2023). Close monitoring, flexible budgeting and diversified outreach are means of mitigation of these risks which have been anticipated in the scenario planning off Chapter 7. The vision to maintain a trusted and inclusive platform and the mission of empowering athletes will be the canon of guiding interest, therefore making sure that the decision made about operations do not go beyond the values along with the financial need (Kaplan and Norton 1996; Kotler and Keller 2022).

8.3 Scaling Years 2–5 (Appendices G)

Starting from the year 2, the operations experience fewer increases in responses to the introduction of merchandise and the live events, which diversify the revenue as per the survey demand (Chapter 2) and in tandem with the industry trends where the merchandise and live experiences are increasing (Statista, 2024; Deloitte, 2023). The break-even will reach third year onwards because of which recurring subscriptions and sponsorships can be levelled, and three to four years will require to break even the digital sports venture as stated by PwC (2023) that states that digital sports ventures tend to break even with three to four years of start. This phase is when the partner and funding alliances are formalised to get organisational capacity in place (Kotler & Keller, 2022).

The focus points in year 4 and 5 are consolidation and expansion. Northern England remains influential towards the growth in their regions, which may be regarded as evidenced of plausibility in the grassroots, one of the arguments that Ratten (2023) concentrates on when it comes to the process of commercial interests and social embeddedness. The presence of international opportunities are evaluated within the framework of the partnership first model of Dugout (SportsBusiness, 2020) and does not get involved in premature scaling traps that are the reasons behind the downfall of OTRO

(Financial Times, 2020). The step-by-step approach will help HIS be a sustainable business that will not violate the principles of inclusive storytelling.

8.4 Evaluation and Control

Conducting the evaluation process also assist in ensuring that the operations are disciplined based with respect to financial matters and mission oriented. The short-term financial management is provided by cash flow and break-even analysis, and the long term measures in the KPIs (Appendices H) measures performance within the subscription, sponsorship, events, liquidity and athlete representation. It is like the Balanced Scorecard by Kaplan and Norton (1996) that incorporated both financial and non-financial outcomes. The inclusion process as a measurable aim, which can be supported by metrics related to the mission, like diversity of featured athletes is the same idea suggested in the article by Ratten (2023) that sports in entrepreneurship must be societally integrated.

The external dependencies are also verified. Instagram and YouTube can modify their algorithm improvement therefore the consistency of the engagement and visibility can be tracked every month using analytics of the platform (Statista, 2024). The quarterly reviews of the cloud hosting and streaming vendors will be split based on the index on cost and uptime (PwC, 2023) such that the delivery of services is resilient. The suggested probabilistic planning by Hillson and Murray-Webster (2007) can be used in facilitating the flexibility of responding to it as it will allow them to resize the events or redirect the marketing spending when the objectives are not achieved. A feedback mechanism constituted by financial monitoring and mission oriented KPIs and monitors of external dependencies which will help HIS establish it's own feedback loop and not lose its touch with value-oriented orientation.

8.5 Summary

The initial year forms a lean yet mission-oriented structure that also recognises risks like depending on freelancers and interns, outsourcing trend and narrow formalisation of sponsorship. It reflects the point by Burns (2016), as he argues about efficient utilisation of resources in a small business and closely resembles the argument of Ries (2011) in the cause of adaptive and lean operations. The development of the years 2-5 is well planned using the diversification model in year 2, break even in year 3 and regional expansion in year 4 and 5 respectively which follows the model of incremental scaling by Hillson and Murray-Webster (2007) and PwC (2023) of digital sports media profitability. Importantly, the analysis is not limited to financial measures but also extends to the inclusivity and diversity KPIs, which is also in line with the balanced scorecard presented by Kaplan and Norton (1996). It goes to strengthen the opinion of Ratten(2023), that the operations of sports ventures need to be characterised by a combination of commercial sustainability and substantial social impact.

Chapter 9: Conclusion & Recommendations

This business plan has shown that HIS is feasible and unique as it is a values driven digital media venture. The market basis offered by the need of including sports stories delivered in Chapter 2 gives good market basis and strategies developed in Chapter 3 and 6 showed how digital first mediums and community purposes can translate this need into sustainable development. In chapters 7 and 8, it has shown how financial discipline, introducing scaling and strong evaluation mechanisms is a plausible route toward profitability. The resultant finding is that the company is most competitive in terms of the kindness of integrating mission and market opportunity.

There are still certain risk remains for HIS Reliance on freelancers and third-party site introduces risks to operations and the unknown level of sponsorship revenue becomes a challenge to liquidity during the initial years in operations. There is also the risk of international expansion and the example of OTRO whose collapse became clear when it increased in scale too soon without a solid domestic foundation (Financial Times, 2020). These observations underline how there is need of evidence-based disciplined growth (Burns, 2016; PwC, 2023).

When developing the recommendations, three priorities are the most relevant when it comes to the development of HIS. To begin with, the business should secure revenue of £15,000 to £20,000 in socially aligned with the sponsors within the first 12 months which should be tracked using the sponsorship renewal KPI discussed in Chapter 8 to increase the authenticity and minimise the risk of insufficient early cash flow (Ratten, 2023). Under the same principle, the second recommendation would be the change of focus to attract more niche and underrepresented athletes on board as starting with Year 2. This way the platform will reinforce its unique value proposition and make new brands associate with the platform as partners because of the uniqueness and inclusivity of these stories about athletes. The effectiveness of this strategy is to be evaluated in terms of the number of established partnerships between the athletes and brands annually and by the retention rates of the sponsors. Last but not the least, the international expansion must be perceived very cautiously and only on Years 4 and 5 when annual revenues would exceed the amount of £50,000. Growth should be based on the partnership-first approach and use the example of Dugout to create sustainability and elimination of overextension risks (SportBusiness, 2020). These recommendations provide an equitable mission, financial sustainability and long-term growth while contributing to scholarships and practice by showing how inclusivity and AI-based discovery align social purpose with business visibility (Bruce, 2016; Newman, 2020). The operationalised strategy like targets, timelines and KPIs is presented in Appendices I.

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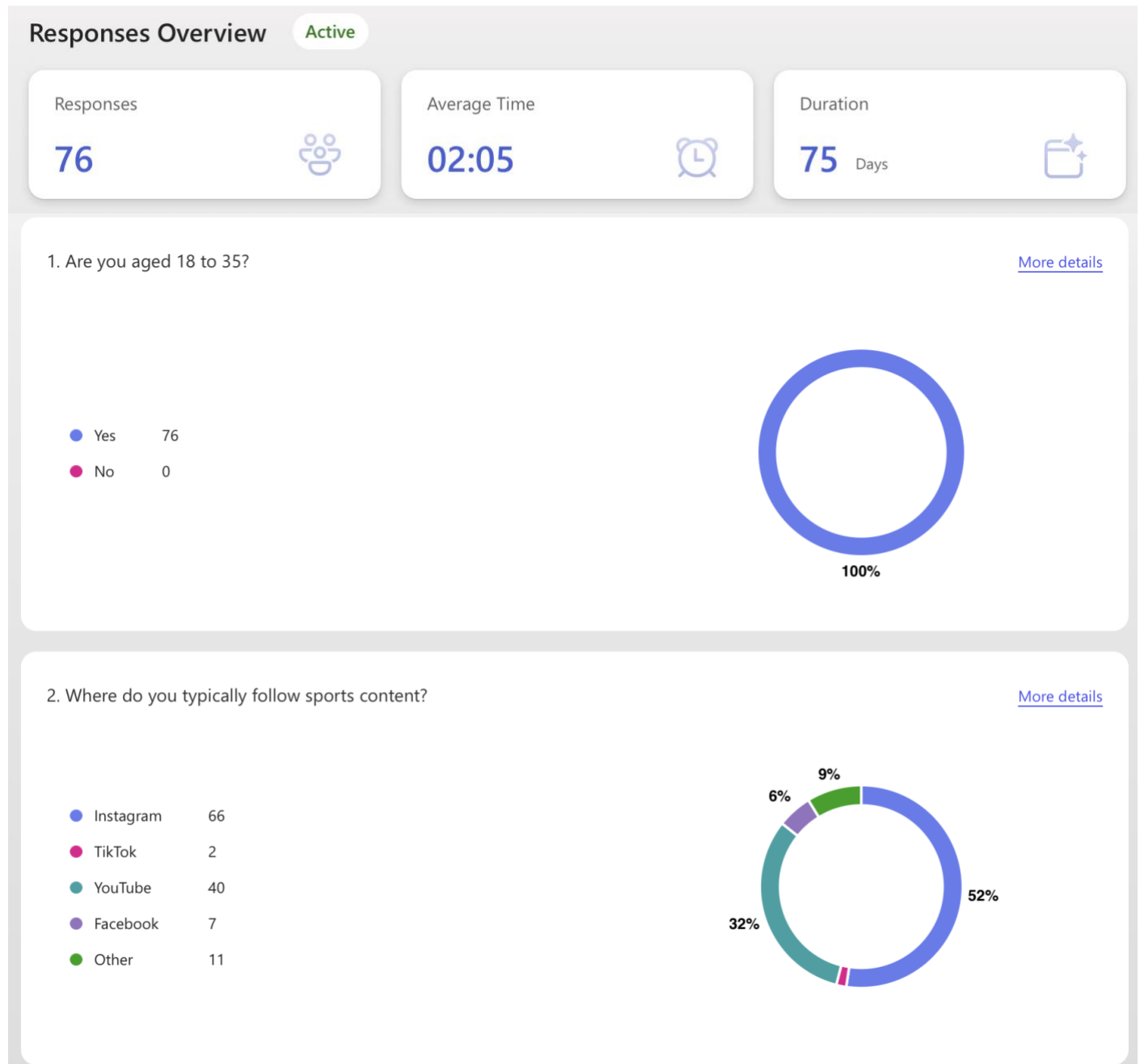
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Appendices

Appendices A: Primary Data Analysis

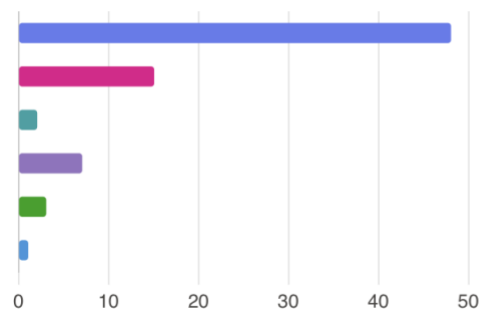
Survey Data with Questions.



3. How often do you engage with sports content on social media?

[More details](#)

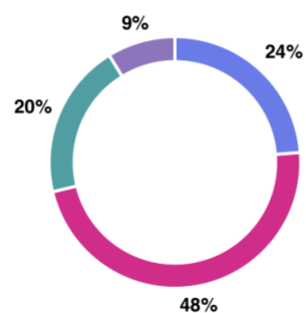
Daily	48
Weekly	15
Monthly	2
Seasonal	7
Yearly	3
Never	1



4. How familiar are you with para-sports, futsal, or other niche sports?

[More details](#)

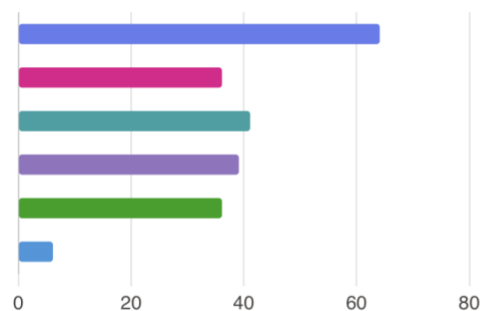
Very Familiar	19
Somewhat Familiar	38
Heard of them	16
Not Familiar at all	7



5. What type of sports content do you enjoy most?

[More details](#)

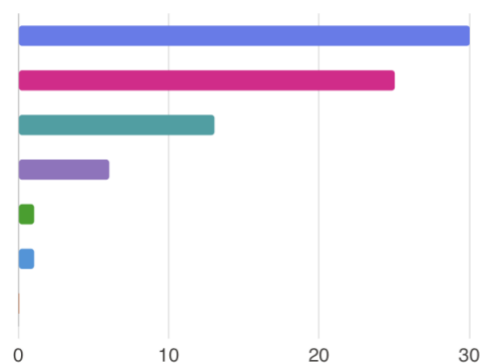
● Match highlights	64
● Player interviews	36
● Behind-the-scenes training clips	41
● Motivational or athlete stories	39
● Humorous or viral moments	36
● Other	6



6. How important is it that lesser-known athletes (e.g. para-athletes, niche athletes or grassroots players) are represented in sports media?

[More details](#)

● Extremely important	30
● Very Important	25
● Important	13
● Moderately Important	6
● Somewhat important	1
● Slightly not important	1
● Extremely not important	0



7. Do you believe mainstream sports media highlights diverse athletic stories enough?

[More details](#)



8. Would you engage with a platform that shares stories of niche and underrepresented athletes?

[More details](#)



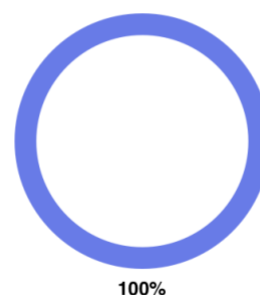
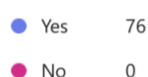
9. Out of the following, please rank your top 3 preferred formats for consuming sports stories.

[More details](#)



10. Are you happy to confirm and submit your responses?

[More details](#)



Appendices A.1 - Frequency of content consumption.

	Frequency	Percent
Daily	48	63
Monthly	2	3
Seasonal	7	9
Weekly	15	20
Yearly	3	4
Never	1	1
Total	76	100

Appendices A.2 - Platform Preference - Where do you typically consume sports content.

Platform	Frequency	Percent(%)
Instagram	66	52
YouTube	40	32

Facebook	7	6
TikTok	2	1
Other	11	9

Appendices A.3 – Familiarity to Niche Sports

Familiarity Level	Frequency	Percent
Very Familiar	19	24
Somewhat Familiar	38	48
Heard of them	16	20
Not Familiar at all	7	9
Total	80	100

Appendices A.4 – Preferred Content Type

Content Type	Frequency	Percent
Match highlights	64	29
Player interviews	36	16
Behind-the-scenes training clips	41	18
Motivational or athlete stories	39	18
Humorous or viral moments	36	16
Other	6	3
Total	222	100

Appendices A.5 – Correlations Table

		Importance representation (numeric)	Media_Diversit y_Rating	Platform_Enga gement_Likeli hood
Importance representation (numeric)	Pearson Correlation	. ^a	. ^a	. ^a
	Sig. (2-tailed)		.	.
	N	29	29	29
Media_Diversity_Rating	Pearson Correlation	. ^a	1	.234 [*]
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.		.044
	N	29	75	75
Platform_Engagement_Likelihood	Pearson Correlation	. ^a	.234 [*]	1
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.	.044	
	N	29	75	75

*. Correlation is significant at the 0.05 level (2-tailed).

a. Cannot be computed because at least one of the variables is constant.

After looking at the primary data, though the willingness to pay to consume exclusive content about the niche athletes was not a direct result of the survey, the results of the conducted secondary research evidently offer adopting subscription based freemium model based on chapter 6.4.2. Within the industry, 2% to 5% of the convertible online media is evidenced (Statista, 2024), which is most cases would be due to premium features such as the backstage access response. A subscription-based model will be reasonable since the value of motivational stories and BTS was 18%. The Athletic and The Players Tribune are using this pattern to strengthen their revenue model (Nagle and Muller, 2018).

Appendices B: Environmental and Competitive Analysis

Appendices B.1 – PESTLE Analysis

External Factors	Key Considerations
Political	- Government initiatives supporting diversity and inclusion in sport (e.g. Sport England, UK Sport). - Alignment with national policy goals and funding opportunities for grassroots and para-sport storytelling.
Economic	- Resilience of digital and sports economies amid economic uncertainty. - Creator economy valued over £100bn; global sports industry projected at £480bn by 2027. - Growth in ethical sponsorship and inclusive marketing.
Social	- Platform appeals to Gen Z and millennial audiences seeking real, inclusive stories. - Emphasis on diverse identities, social values, and representation. - Strong social media engagement and online community building.
Technological	- Integration of AI tools for talent discovery and content generation. - Use of social platforms (YouTube, Instagram) for digital storytelling. - Reliance on evolving technologies and platform algorithms.
Legal	- GDPR compliance in handling athlete data, images, and consent. - Legal rights for content usage, athlete representation, and IP. - Responsible governance in working with minors and vulnerable individuals.

Environmental	- Fully digital platform reduces travel and production waste. - Alignment with UN Sustainable Development Goals, particularly SDG 5 (Gender Equality) and SDG 10 (Reduced Inequalities).
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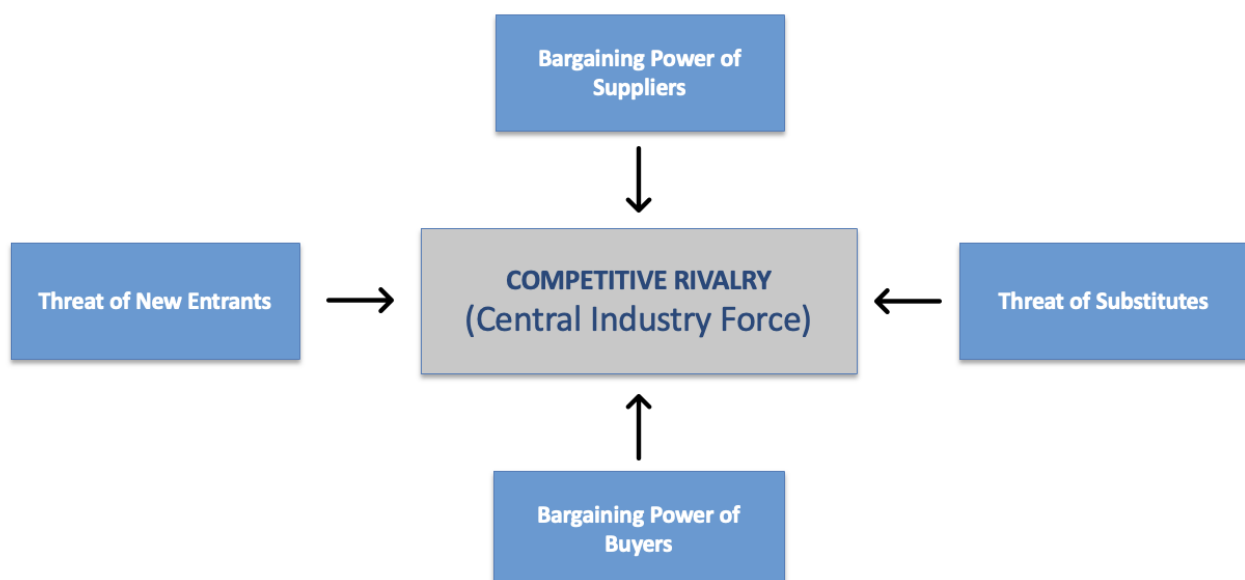
Factor	Opportunity / Threat	Impact (1–5)	Probability (1–5)	Weighted Score	Strategic Implication
Political	Opportunity: Government policies and funding support diversity in sport. Threat: policy shifts or reduced grassroots funding.	3	3	0.3	Align with UK Sport/Sport England to secure legitimacy and access funding.
Economic	Opportunity: Growth of creator economy (£100bn+) and global sports market (£480bn by 2027). Threat: economic downturn reducing sponsorship budgets.	3	3	0.45	Build diverse revenue streams via ethical sponsorships and brand partnerships.
Social	Opportunity: Gen Z demand for authentic, inclusive stories and digital engagement. Threat: rapid shifts in audience preferences.	5	5	1.25	Position as a socially responsible platform with strong community focus.
Technological	Opportunity: AI tools and social media platforms for scalable storytelling. Threat: dependency on changing algorithms.	5	5	1.25	Invest in AI-driven content tools and maintain multi-platform presence.
Legal	Opportunity: Clear governance builds trust. Threat: GDPR breaches or IP disputes.	3	3	0.3	Implement strong compliance protocols for data, consent, and representation rights.

Environmental	Opportunity: Digital-first reduces waste, aligns with SDGs (5 & 10). Threat: risk of greenwashing if claims not backed by action.	4	4	0.6	Emphasise sustainability in partnerships and reporting to strengthen brand value.
Total				4.15 / 5	Overall favourable environment for growth.

Weighted PESTLE Scoring Matrix

The PESTLE opportunity-threat analysis indicates that Social and Technological forces are the most compelling factors of HIS by having the Gen Z desire to listen to authentic stories and the potential of digital platforms to scale up creating obvious growth opportunities. Potential is also presented in Economic and Environmental terms through sponsorship and sustainability, however threats like budget constraints or greenwashing would have to be addressed. Political and Legal issues are not so dominant but also play a significant role in compliance and legitimacy. The external environment has a weighted score of 4.15/5, which indicates that it is very favourable to the long-term success.

Appendices B.2 – Porter’s Five Forces



Appendices B.3 – Blue Ocean Strategy

RAISE Community involvement Diversity of athletes Truth in narrative	REDUCE Costly production Broadcast infrastructure
ELIMINATE Celebrity-driven narratives dominating mainstream media	CREATE AI-powered discovery Inclusive storytelling Emotional connection

Appendices B.4 – Ansoff Matrix - HIS Growth Strategy

Strategy	Description
Market Penetration	Target Gen Z and millennials on Instagram, YouTube, and Spotify. Partner with NGOs and universities to build trust and boost visibility.
Product Development	Launch AI-powered discovery engine, interactive live content, storytelling workshops, and branded athlete apparel to enhance engagement.
Market Development	Expand to Southeast Asia, Sub-Saharan Africa, and South America. Localise content and partner with federations using multi-lingual strategies.

Diversification	Offer consulting services to sports brands and federations for inclusive campaigns. Establish a non-profit to support young talent and extend social impact.
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Appendices C – Social Media Content Plan

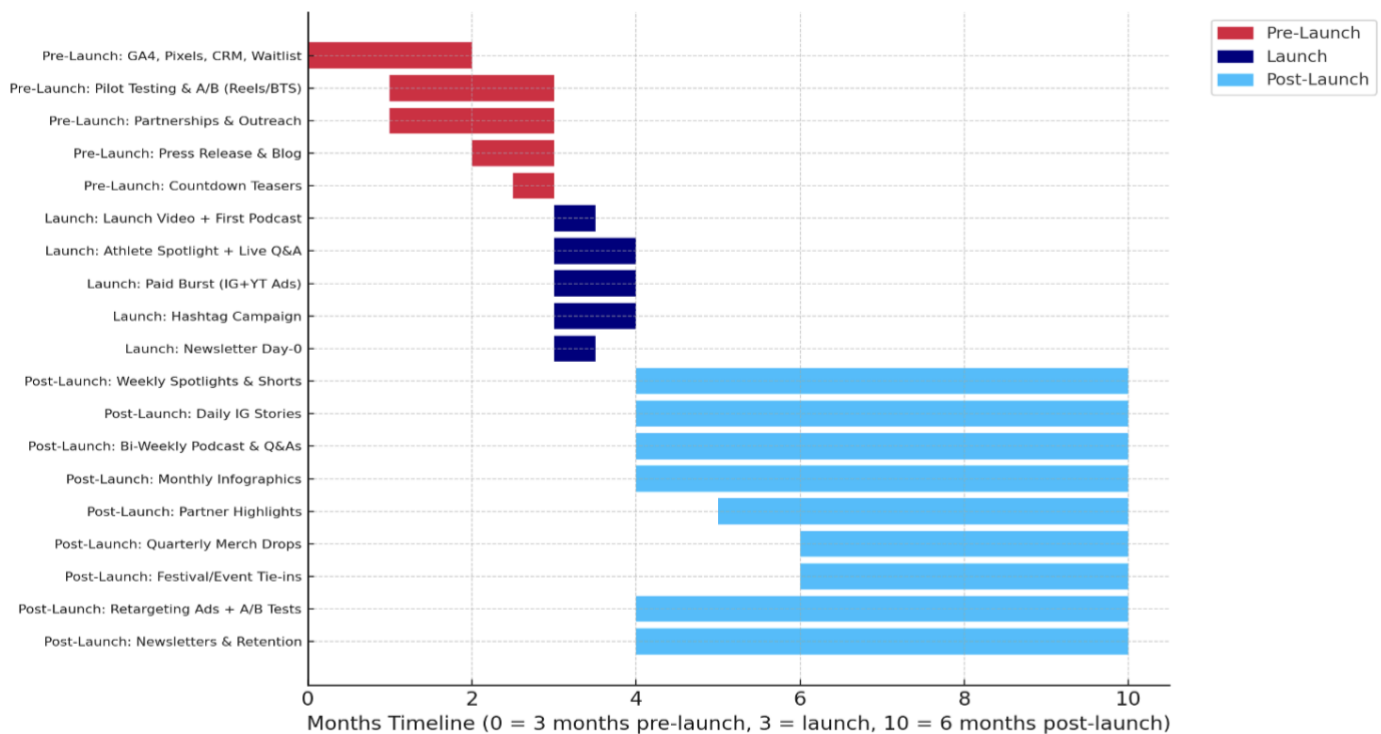
Content Type	Description	Platforms	Frequency	Target Audience	Goals	Metrics	Funnel Stage	Primary CTA	Primary Research Evidence	Success Target
Launch Countdown Series	Teaser graphics/videos building hype pre-launch	Instagram, TikTok, YT Shorts, Twitter	Daily (10 days pre-launch)	Gen Z & Millennials	Build anticipation	Engagement, follower growth	Reach	Follow & share	64% daily/weekly content consumers	+20% IG followers
Athlete Spotlights	Weekly reels & monthly long-form videos on unsung athletes	Instagram Reels, YouTube, LinkedIn	Weekly (shorts/reels), Monthly (long-form YT)	Niche athletes, fans, grassroots	Showcase raw talent & diversity	Video views, comments, shares	Act	Subscribe for full story	52% want deeper narratives	10% CTR to bio links
Podcast Teasers	Clips with athlete insights to drive full listens	Instagram, Spotify Audiograms, Twitter, LinkedIn	Bi-weekly	Sports enthusiasts	Boost podcast reach	Streams, listens, engagement	Act	Listen now	32% prefer YouTube/Spotify	1,000 listens/episode
AI Discovery Feature	Graphics/reels showing AI talent identification	Instagram, TikTok, YouTube	Monthly	Tech-savvy fans, analysts	Highlight innovation	Shares, mentions, reach	Reach/Act	Try our tool	55% value BTS & data insights	200 tool sign-ups/month
Interactive Content	Polls, quizzes, Q&As, contests like 'Nominate an Unsung Hero'	Instagram Stories, Twitter, LinkedIn	Weekly + daily Stories	All audiences	Drive participation	Poll entries, UGC, Story engagement	Engage	Vote & tag us	64% frequent content consumers	8% Story engagement rate
Behind-the-Scenes (BTS)	Studio footage, athlete interviews, editing process	Instagram, YT Shorts, TikTok	2-3x weekly	Younger fans	Humanise the brand	Engagement rate, shares	Engage/Convert	Subscribe for BTS	55% enjoy BTS content	30% 15s+ retention

Content Type	Description	Platforms	Frequency	Target Audience	Goals	Metrics	Funnel Stage	Primary CTA	Primary Research Evidence	Success Target
Impact Posts	Infographics highlighting barriers & stats for niche athletes	LinkedIn, Instagram	Monthly	Investors, partners, fans	Show credibility	Saves, shares, impressions	Engage	Read full report	72% value representation	500 saves/month
Festival/Event Tie-ins	Posts linked with major sports events	Instagram, Twitter, LinkedIn	As relevant	Broad sports audience	Stay timely & relevant	Event engagement, hashtag use	Reach/Engage	Follow live updates	Daily/weekly habits	Hashtag reach >50k
Partnership Highlights	Features with collaborators & sponsors	Instagram, LinkedIn, Twitter	Bi-monthly	Sponsors, corporates	Showcase collaborations	Partner mentions, reach	Engage	See our partners	NGOs/secondary audience	5 co-branded posts/quarter
Merchandise & Promos	Limited edition HIS merchandise drops	Instagram, TikTok, FB Shop	Quarterly	Fans, collectors	Revenue & loyalty	Sales, traffic	Convert	Buy now	High willingness scores	£5k monthly sales
Email Capture & Newsletter	Launch waitlist, digest, exclusive offers	Website, Email (CRM)	Weekly	Core followers & premium audience	Retention & owned audience	Open rate, CTR, growth	Convert/Engage	Sign up now	High willingness-to-engage	2,000 subs in 6 months

Appendices D.1 – Marketing Budget Allocation

Marketing Channel	Allocation (£)	% of Total Marketing Budget
Digital Marketing	15,000	30%
Content Marketing	9,000	18%
Influencer Collaborations	9,500	19%
Experiential Marketing	6,500	13%
Public Relations	3,500	7%
Marketing Analytics & Tools	3,500	7%
Creative & Design Costs	2,000	4%
Contingency Reserve	2,000	4%
Total	49,000	100%

Appendices D.1 – Grantt Style Marketing Timeline



Aligning the athlete spotlights, behind the scenes features and interactive campaign with the survey results on content preferences along with the marketing budget proposed, the plan will help make sure that HIS values authenticity and inclusiveness which are embedded across all touchpoints. This is complimented by the Gantt Chart, which chains the activities throughout the pre-launch, launch and post launch and reinforce the IMC principle of the coherence principle and remained agile in the execution process (Schultz & Kitchen, 2000; Chaffey & Ellis-Chadwick, 2019).

Appendices E: Financial Plan

Appendices E.1 – Equity Dilution Scenarios

Scenario	Angel Investment (£)	Equity Stake Taken	Founder Retention	Implications
A	50,000	10%	90%	Modest dilution; preserves control.
B	100,000	20%	80%	Stronger liquidity; faster scaling.
C	150,000	30%	70%	Higher dilution; risk of control loss.

HIS will have a diversified financial strategy by incorporating grants, sponsorships, equity and entrepreneurships as part of the funds which must equally count on the capital structure theory developed by Modigliani and Miller (1958), proposing the principle of sustainability amongst the financial sources within its constructions (Fiorno et al, 2007). Sponsorships deals will move beyond

advertising and adopting equity-based partnerships and contra deals as recommended by Cornwell (2008) or sponsorship as a strategically based brand building risk and Freeman (1984) stakeholder theory which holds the view of aligning organisational values with stakeholders expectations. HIS has incorporated the concept of inclusiveness and empowerment in its financing, which depicts the CSR frameworks of Carroll (1991) and the triple bottom line of Elkington (1997). Thus the capital will not rely on founder capital, it will help to be liquid and long-term which will in turn support the mission to help niche athletes.

Appendices E.2 – Month-by-Month Cash Flow Forecast (Year 1)

Month	Inflows (£)	Outflows (£)	Net Flow (£)	Closing Balance (£)
Jan	15,500	29,250	-13,750	-13,750
Feb	500	2,750	-2,250	-16,000
Mar	1,500	2,750	-1,250	-17,250
Apr	1,500	2,450	-950	-18,200
May	1,500	2,350	-850	-19,050
Jun	11,500	2,150	9,350	-9,700
Jul	1,500	2,050	-550	-10,250
Aug	500	1,950	-1,450	-11,700
Sep	500	1,950	-1,450	-13,150
Oct	500	1,350	-850	-14,000
Nov	500	1,300	-800	-14,800
Dec	500	1,300	-800	-15,600

The Year 1 month-by-month cash flow forecast simply illustrates the general financial trend of a start-up where the total inflows on the basis of subscription (£500 to £1500 per month), initial grant of £5,000, socially oriented sponsorships paid on January and June and seasonal event income during spring and summer turn out. The outflows amount to £51600 and was comprised of some fixed operating costs of around £25000 (content production, marketing, operations and events) as well as a one-off launch cost totalling about £26000 in January, which was used in the platform development, branding and various legal requirements. The venture therefore ends up the year with a net deficit of -£15600, which is exactly as outshining the balance as determined in the forecasts of December. This effect indicates well-reported J-curve in the entrepreneurial finance as high initial spending is followed by the clouding of the revenue streams (Kaplan and Stromberg, 2003; Burns, 2016). This is the part where such deficits are anticipated and will be addressed by the means of the angel investment and grants (Atrill & McLaney, 2019), laying the premises in sustainable growth in the following years.

Appendices E.3 – Revenue and Gross Margins (Years 1–5)

Revenue Stream	Y1 (£)	Y2 (£)	Y3 (£)	Y4 (£)	Y5 (£)	Gross Margin %
Subscriptions	6,000	12,000	18,000	24,000	30,000	90%
Sponsorships	20,000	28,000	32,000	36,000	40,000	95%
Merchandise	–	5,000	7,500	10,000	12,000	40%
Events & Workshops	5,000	10,000	15,000	20,000	25,000	60%
Crowdfunding/Grants	5,000	5,000	–	–	–	100%
Total Revenue	36,000	60,000	72,500	90,000	107,000	–

Online subscription and sponsorship is margin of 92 – 95 percent and thus the most efficient source of revenue. Merchandise which has a margin of approximately 40% and events which have their margins at around 60% hold a greater production and operation cost but strategically they have been important in engaging the audience and brand building along with getting back the cash. Where applicable, crowdfunding and grants give 100% margin inflows during the initial two years. The shift towards the proportion of high margins digital returns to lower margin tangible products confirm the significance of subscriptions and branded collaborations as attaches to sustainability in financial terms and also the fact that the brand would still be a connecting element in its community.

Appendices E.4 – Fixed Operating Budget Allocation (Years 1–5)

Category	Year 1 (£)	Year 2 (£)	Year 3 (£)	Year 4 (£)	Year 5 (£)
Content Production	10,000	12,000	14,000	15,000	17,000
Marketing & PR	7,000	8,500	10,000	11,000	12,500
Operations & Tech	5,000	5,500	6,000	6,500	7,000
Events & Community	3,000	5,000	6,500	8,000	9,500
Merchandise	–	2,000	3,000	4,500	6,000
Overheads/Admin	–	2,500	3,000	4,500	6,000
Total	25,000	35,500	42,500	49,500	58,000

In addition to the initial priorities, the plan will cover consistent operational and technology investments such as AI based talent discovery tool explained chapter 3. Such costs are gradualised in note of the secondary benefits and threats of technological change as noted in chapter 4 which examines the PESTEL analysis of change. Starting in year 2, spending shifts to events and community involvement, on the basis of survey results that audience wants to do more than just interact with athletes on screen. This allocation is also backed by the analysis of experiential fan trends at Deloitte (2023) that aims to build revenue but also support brand credibility and grassroots relations.

During the second year, the merchandise is also introduced with an indicator of the constant growth of global market in this segment, which is projected by Statista (2024). Although the production and distribution overheads make merchandise list profitable than other assets, it allows interacting more with audience and athletes, providing them with more physical connections. Other costs like overheads and administration such as legal, insurance cover and staffing are planned to be rolled out over a long period to allow sufficient time to absorb this expense, only committed in line with the needs of the organisation. Overall, the expenditure model strikes a ratio between need to launch and diversification at a medium-term level, where every single location is based on the result of the integration of survey, IMC approach and industry standards. This evidence-based practise makes sure financial resources are directed in those areas that are most likely to yield output and sustainable growth.

Appendices E.5 – Visual Financial Revenue Mix.

Year	Subscriptions (£)	Sponsorships (£)	Merchandise (£)	Events (£)	Grants (£)	Total (£)
Year 1	5,000	20,000	0	5,000	6,000	36,000
Year 2	11,000	29,000	5,000	9,000	6,000	60,000
Year 3	18,000	32,000	8,000	14,000	0	72,000
Year 4	24,000	36,000	10,000	20,000	0	90,000
Year 5	30,000	40,000	12,000	25,000	0	107,000

Figure 7.1: Revenue Mix Evolution (Years 1–5)

It shows the process of diversification of this kind of revenue in the course of the next five years. Although as a cash source, it shares the top spot with most of the mixes being dominated by sponsorship, the share of events, subscriptions, and merchandise grows successively as the presence of sponsorship reduces. Strategy intention, which is to shift the existing situation of dependence on the external sponsors to a more balanced and recurring revenue base by the Year 5 is reinforced by the visual.

Appendices E.6 – Projected Balance Sheet (Years 1–5)

Year	Assets (£)	Liabilities (£)	Equity (£)	Notes
Year 1	25,000	40,000	-15,000	Initial deficit due to start-up investments.
Year 2	35,500	30,500	5,000	Break-even achieved.
Year 3	42,500	32,500	10,000	Liquidity strengthens.
Year 4	49,500	29,500	20,000	Reinvestment for expansion.
Year 5	58,000	28,000	30,000	Sustainable equity achieved.

The balance sheet has shown that there was an evident way that an initial negative equity can be translated into cumulative surpluses over the Years 1-5. This is a reflection of J-curve in entrepreneurial financing (Kaplan and Stromberg, 2003) and it concurs the break-even curve that would be registered by the forecast of cash flow.

Appendices E.7 – Risk Analysis and Mitigation

Risk	Probability	Impact	Mitigation Strategy
Funding shortfall	Medium	High	Diversify revenue streams, phased launch
Platform dependency	High	Medium	Multi-platform strategy, own website/app
Legal/IP disputes	Low	High	Strong contracts, GDPR compliance protocols
Audience stagnation	Medium	Medium	Regular engagement, influencer partnerships
Reputational risks	Low	Medium	Transparent sustainability reporting

Appendices E.8 - Visual Financial Cash Flow

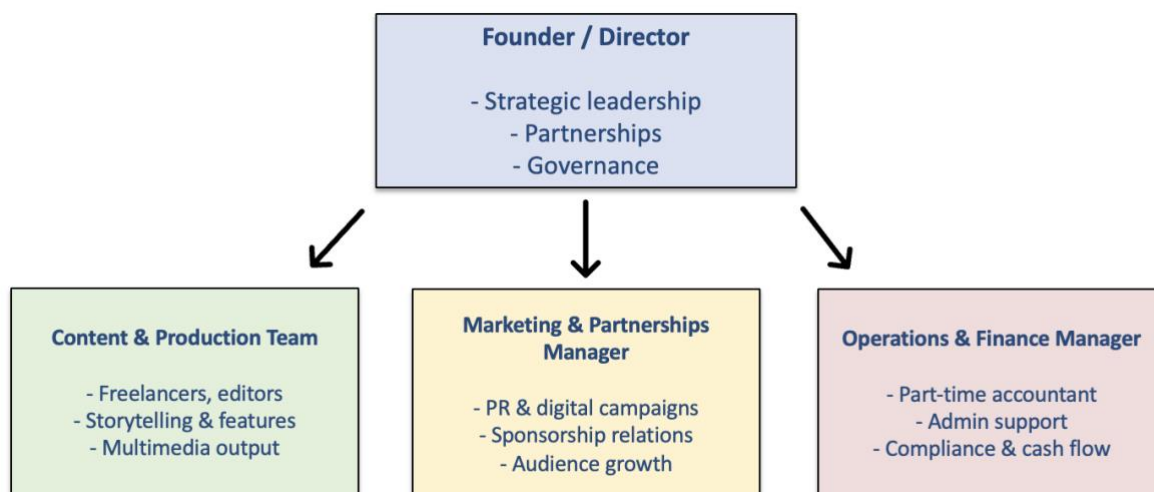
Year	Net Cash Flow (£)
Year 1	-15,000
Year 2	5,000
Year 3	10,000
Year 4	20,000
Year 5	30,000

Figure 7.2: Net Cash Flow (Years 1–5)

It is a line chart that will follow net cash flow between Years 1 and 5. Deficits in Year 1 are justified by the start-up expenses speculated, yet further years report the growing of cash balances to the advantage. The venture breakeven after Year 3, and sustainable positive cash position is realised after Year 5. The analysis of break-even and risk management presented in Section 7.3 is backed by this direction. Thus, HIS is able to establish itself as a financially sustainable and mission appropriate. The approach therefore does not only show a route to profit margins, it also provides a framework of questionable long term and ethical advancement.

Appendices F – Organisational Structure (Years 1–3)

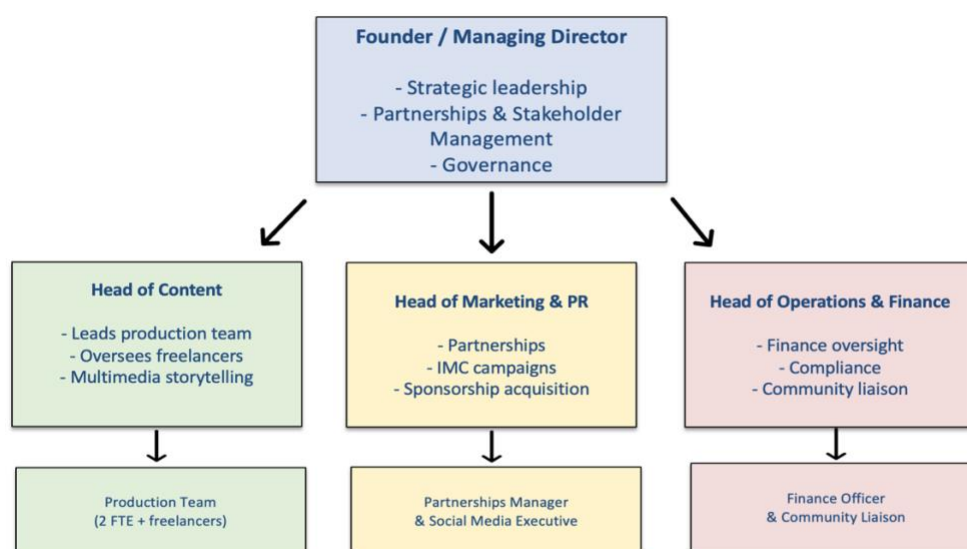
Figure F.1: Organisational Chart (Year 1)



Year 1

- The Founder/Director will be one to overlook and manage all three functions directly.
- Content & Production will directly rely on the freelancers/interns who will maintain flexibility and help in controlling the overall cost.
- In the Marketing and Partnership team, it will consist of one core member who will manage the interns/freelancers directly for the required campaigns and assign tasks regularly.
- The Operations and the Finance department will be either outsourced or handled by part time professionals (accountant, legal support).

Figure F.2 Organisational Chart (Year 3-5 – Scaling at Break-even)



Year 3 - 5

- In the year 3-5 by break-even the functions are more professionalised into proper department heads.
- The Production team now consist of 2 full time employees supported by freelancers as well as interns.
- The Marketing teams expands with a Partnership Manager and dedicated content and social media team.
- The operations team adds a Finance Officer and a Community Liaison who will manage major events and outreach.

Appendices G – Organisational Scaling (Years 2–5)

Year	Organisational Development	Key Additions	Link to Financial Commentary	Risks/Dependencies
Year 2	Diversification begins	Event coordinator; merchandise designer	Supports event delivery and merchandise roll-out (Ch.7, App. C).	Reliance on third-party suppliers; venue access.
Year 3	Break-even achieved	Partnerships manager; part-time finance officer	Ensures renewal of sponsorships and accurate reporting at scale.	Risk of overextension if revenues underperform; need for CRM software.
Year 4	Regional expansion	Community engagement officers in northern England	Supports outreach for local events and partnerships.	Dependence on local sports clubs/venues; travel costs.
Year 5	Consolidation	Head of operations; content strategist	Professionalises management and prepares for international partnerships.	Dependence on digital infrastructure; cross-border legal/regulatory risks.

Appendices H – Key Performance Indicators (KPIs, Years 1–5)

Table H.1: Evaluation Framework for HIS

Area	KPI	Target (Year 1)	Target (Year 3)	Target (Year 5)	Evaluation Tool	Data Source	Strategic Link
Subscriptions	Churn rate	<10% monthly	<8% monthly	<5% monthly	Subscription analytics	Google Analytics; CRM	Aligns with Chapter 2 survey on willingness to pay.
Sponsorships	Renewal rate	–	75%	85%	Sponsorship CRM tracking	Internal contracts; CRM	Ensures stability of early revenue streams.
Events	ROI per event	≥20% margin	≥25% margin	≥30% margin	Event budget reports	Ticketing system; P&L	Links to Deloitte (2023) evidence on experiential growth.
Finance	Liquidity reserve	≥3 months' OpEx	≥4 months' OpEx	≥6 months' OpEx	Cash flow monitoring	Management accounts	Matches Chapter 7's risk management strategy.
Mission alignment	Diversity of athletes featured	≥50% underrepresented groups	≥60%	≥70%	Content audit	Internal editorial review	Reflects inclusivity values (Chapter 1).

Table H.1 identifies the KPIs headlines that would be employed in assessing the performance of HIS in the initial five years. Based upon the Balanced Scorecard framework as put forward by Kaplan and Norton (1996), these metrics respond to each other; the financial performance (subscriptions, sponsorships, liquidity) and the mission-driven ones (diversity of the athletes). There will be a phased development of targets over Years 1, 3, and 5 in line with growth and consolidation. This will make sure that you evaluate short-term milestones, and strategic accomplishments in the long-term.

Table H.2: KPI Monitoring Schedule and Responsibility

KPI Area	Monitoring Frequency	Responsible Role (Year 1)	Responsible Role (Year 3)	Reporting Mechanism
Subscription churn	Monthly	Marketing & PR lead	Partnerships Manager	Monthly analytics dashboard; quarterly board review
Sponsorship renewal	Bi-annual	Founder/Director	Head of Marketing & PR	Sponsorship CRM reports; board updates
Event ROI	Per event	Operations support (outsourced)	Community Liaison	Event P&L analysis; annual summary report
Liquidity reserve	Quarterly	Founder (with accountant)	Finance Officer	Cash flow statement; break-even analysis
Athlete diversity	Quarterly	Founder/Content lead	Head of Content	Content audit report; annual review of representation

As shown in Table H.2, the KPI monitoring responsibility would not be handled under the professionalised management as it would be in Year 3, but under founder-led. This is the organisational

scaling mentioned in Appendices G and will keep the mechanisms of evaluation involving systems changed as the organisation grows. Monitoring plan also validates that the various KPIs need varying degrees of attention, since churn is verified monthly, sponsorship renewal twice a year, liquidity once in three months, and athlete diversity once in three months. The dynamic level structure establishes a rhythm of operation reviews that promote agility and responsibility.

Appendices I – Summary of Recommendations, KPIs and Timelines

Recommendation	Timeline	Quantified Target	KPI Monitoring
Secure socially aligned sponsorships	Year 1	£15,000–£20,000 sponsorship secured	Sponsorship renewal KPI (Chapter 8)
Onboard niche/underrepresented athletes with brand partners	Years 2–3	Min. 5 athlete–brand partnerships per year; sponsor retention rate >70%	Partnership count and sponsor retention KPIs
Cautious international expansion	Years 4–5	Annual revenue ≥ £50,000 before expansion	Liquidity reserve KPI

Future Research

Theoretical comparative cases of sports media start-up are recommended to explore, in order to optimise the internationalisation policies, the evaluation of the consumer rewards at a wider duration, the role of the new technologies or signals of using AI-assisted consumer interactions (Deloitte, 2023). This is not only an addition to the genesis of HIS but also to scholarly discourses about the framework of sport, media and social value intersection.

